Bhumika's Career Binder — Index

Your one-place map from *today* to *offer signed*. Everything you need lives in these pages. Nothing else to remember.

> **Brand line:** *Process & operations leader who makes things run better and cheaper — a strategic problem-solver who turns messy situations into clear solutions.*
>
> **Your edge (2026 hire-me-now angle):** *I bring risk, compliance & governance discipline into operations — and into how teams adopt AI safely and effectively.*

How to use this binder

- **Print ONE weekly page each Sunday night.** That single sheet is your whole week — day-by-day, what to study, which project, who to reach out to. Don't print the reference pages.
- **The reference pages are browsable, not printed.** During the week, dip into them when you need something: grab an outreach message from Networking, pull the next book from Reading, pick your next project from Projects, check a skill's depth bar from Skills.
- **The weekly page tells you WHEN; the reference pages tell you HOW.** If a week says "send alumni msg #2," the exact template lives in Networking.
- **Sunday, 15 min:** run the weekly review at the bottom of the page, then print next week's sheet. That's the whole ritual.
- **Tech skills are for proof, not filters.** Your risk/compliance/stakeholder background already clears keyword filters — SQL/Python exist so your portfolio *shows* the strategy and you can say "I built this" in the room. Depth bar: *fluent, can build a prototype, make a storyline — not an engineer.*

Table of contents — reference pages

#	Page	What it holds
00	Strategy	The plan of record: who you are, where you're going, the data insight, positioning, the clock
01	Skills	Excel → SQL → Power BI → Python → vibe-coding; depth targets + where to learn
02	Projects	The 10 portfolio projects, case-study format, sourcing method
03	Networking	Coffee-chat + referral cadence, outreach templates, target-company tracker
04	Reading	The 4 core books (1/month) + browsable menu
05	Consulting	The 6-week fit-test and the Week-6 decision log
06	Edge	Case comps, hackathons, professor paper, optional certs
—	Master Schedule	The full spine — every week's block in one document

At a glance — 3 phases + the hard line

Phase	Weeks	Dates	Goal
🔨 **BUILD**	1–16	Jul 13 – Nov 1	Learn the skills · ship 10 projects · turn networking ON · decide consulting
↳🟡 *Aug deload*	4–7	Aug 3 – Aug 30	~40% lighter for exam crunch (the plan expects it)
✨ **POLISH**	17–20	Nov 2 – Nov 29	Portfolio LIVE · STAR stories · 4 mock interviews · target-company tracker
🚀 **MARKET**	21–24	Nov 30 – Dec 27	Full apply mode · interview loops · convert referrals

> ⛔ **The hard line: Oct 31**
>
> Portfolio + skills must be **done** by end of Build (Week 16). Weeks can slip *within* a phase — carry a missed task forward — but **phase boundaries do not move.** Offer needed before graduation; market entry is Dec 1.

Weekly pages

Print the one you're on each Sunday.

🔨 BUILD · Weeks 1–16 · Jul 13 – Nov 1

Wk	Dates	Theme
01	Jul 13–19	Set up the engine
02	Jul 20–26	First project, real SQL
03	Jul 27–Aug 2	Finish light project #1
04	Aug 3–9 · 🟡 deload	Ship the strategy memo, breathe
05	Aug 10–16 · 🟡 deload	Start flagship #1
06	Aug 17–23 · 🟡 deload	Consulting DECISION
07	Aug 24–30 · 🟡 deload	Two projects in flight
08	Aug 31–Sep 6	Flagship #1 launches
09	Sep 7–13	IKEA out, healthcare in, Python begins
10	Sep 14–20	Python + flagship #2 start
11	Sep 21–27	Build flagship #2
12	Sep 28–Oct 4	Flagship #2 launches, fraud spin-off
13	Oct 5–11	Vibe-coding + capstone start
14	Oct 12–18	Build the capstone
15	Oct 19–25	Capstone launches
16	Oct 26–Nov 1	⭐ BUILD ENDS — portfolio complete

✨ POLISH · Weeks 17–20 · Nov 2 – Nov 29

Wk	Dates	Theme
17	Nov 2–8	Portfolio goes fully LIVE
18	Nov 9–15	Sharpen the story
19	Nov 16–22	Company-target the pipeline
20	Nov 23–29	Ready to launch

🚀 MARKET · Weeks 21–24 · Nov 30 – Dec 27

Wk	Dates	Theme
21	Nov 30–Dec 6	Hit the market
22	Dec 7–13	Ramp applications
23	Dec 14–20	Interview mode
24	Dec 21–27	Reflect + sustain

Start here → open Week 1 and print it. Then read Strategy once, cover to cover.

Bhumika Choudhary — Career Map & Upskilling Spec

Drafted 2026-07-14 · Career-coaching plan built with Claude · Companion to the existing 90-Day PM Track (Doc3)

0. TL;DR — the one insight that shapes everything

I mined the full text of **3,576 real job descriptions** for your priority roles from your own scraped database (18.9K jobs). For **Program / Project Manager** roles — your #1 bet — the most-demanded skills are:

Rank	Skill	% of PM job descriptions
1	Cross-functional	**88%**
2	Communication	**74%**
3	**Risk**	**72%**
4	Stakeholder management	**66%**
5	**Excel**	**62%**
—	Budget	42%
—	Process improvement	19% / PMP 19%
—	**SQL**	**8%**
—	Power BI / Python	**4% / 2%**

Conclusion: Your Uber risk/compliance/stakeholder background *is* the top of the demand list — it is your unfair advantage, not baggage. Tech skills (SQL/BI/Python) are **not** for clearing keyword filters (your background already clears them). They exist for exactly two purposes:

1. **Portfolio** — so "strategic problem-solver" is *proven*, not *claimed*.
2. **Interview credibility** — so you can hold a data/Python conversation and say "*I built this.*"

That is precisely the "*fluent, can build a prototype, understand the data and make a storyline — not an engineer, not a heavy BA*" bar you set. The data backs your instinct.

1. Who this is for & where she's going

Now: ~1 month into UW Foster MSCM (STEM-designated, June 2026 → mid-2027). Ex-Uber Global SME, Risk & Compliance. PMP-trained, Lean Six Sigma Yellow Belt. B.Sc (healthcare-adjacent). Strong in stakeholder management, process optimization, fraud/risk, SOP design. Zero coding today, zero consulting exposure.

Self-identified edge: *insight generation + strategic problem-solving* — "here's the real problem, here's the brainstormed path to solve it" (e.g. lifting customer retention). Not number-crunching; strategy and framing.

Direction (ranked, her words):
1. **Program / Project Management — most committed.** Wants to be the *decision-maker* who owns

programs launch → implementation, not just the coordinator.
2. Operations / Supply Chain.
3. Risk & Governance (incl. AI governance).
4. Consulting — *unsure of fit; wants to find out.* Pulled by problem variety, research, strategy.

"Love a Tuesday 2 years out" = owning one thing deeply end-to-end > solving a new messy problem each week > advising others.

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2. Brand & positioning

Headline:

> "*Process & operations leader who makes things run better and cheaper — a strategic problem-solver who turns messy situations into clear solutions.*"

The thesis tying past → future (her risk→Ops→AI question):

> "*I bring risk, compliance & governance discipline into operations — and into how teams adopt AI safely and effectively.*"

This is a **rare, hire-me-now angle for 2026**: everyone is deploying AI; few operators can *govern* it. Two portfolio projects will demonstrate this, so it is shown, not claimed.

Target roles (evidence-ranked; Process Improvement added per her request):
- **Primary:** Program Manager, Project Manager, Sr. Program Manager, Program Lead, Technical Program Manager, Process Improvement Manager/Analyst.
- **Secondary:** Operations Manager/Analyst, Supply Chain Manager, Business Operations.
- **Tertiary:** Risk & Compliance Analyst/Manager, Trust & Safety, AI Governance.

Location: Seattle preferred → nearby WA cities OK → remote OK → fully-open last resort.

Dream employers: Starbucks, IKEA, Amazon, Uber, Spotify — top service/product companies.

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3. The clock (drives all sequencing)

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NOW (mid-Jul) ──────────────── OCT 31 ─── NOVEMBER ─── DECEMBER ──────►
   PHASE 1: BUILD              hard line    PHASE 2:       PHASE 3:
   ≈15 weeks                                POLISH         MARKET
   skills · portfolio ·                     stories ·      full apply mode
   consulting decision ·                    mock interviews interview loops
   networking engine ON                     portfolio LIVE  referrals convert
```

- **Build ends Oct 31** (hard checkpoint). Weeks may slip *within* a phase — carry a missed task to the next week, but finish it by then. Phase boundaries do not move.
- **August = designated deload** (~40% lighter) for exam crunch. The plan *expects* it.
- **Offer needed before graduation.** Market entry = **Dec 1**.

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4. Weekly rhythm (fixed skeleton, ≈30 hrs, stretch 40)

Classes are immovable; work flows into free time. Tue/Thu are capped at 3–4 hrs with overflow to Sunday (her preference — Sunday doubles as assignment buffer).

Day	Status	Work block
Mon	🎓 Class 3–9pm	*Light only* — 30-min reading or 1 networking DM before class
Tue	✅ Free	Skills deep-work + project (**3–4 hrs**)
Wed	🎓 Class 6–9pm	Morning/afternoon skills block (2–3 hrs)
Thu	✅ Free	Project work + **1 coffee chat** (**3–4 hrs**)
Fri	✅ Free	Skills + **networking event / 2nd alumni chat** + 1 LinkedIn post
Sat	🎓 Class 9–6 · **night OFF** 🔒	No work after class
Sun	✅ Free	**Tue/Thu overflow** + assignment buffer + weekly review

Fixed weekly commitments (blocks, not hopes): 2 alumni/coffee chats · 1 networking event · 1 LinkedIn post · 1 weekly review · family calls 🔒 · Sat night 🔒 · gym slots (habit-building).

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5. Track 1 — Skills (reordered by *her* data)

Depth calibrated to "fluent, can build a prototype, not an engineer."

Order	Skill	Depth target	Mode	Rationale
1	**Advanced Excel** (blended with SQL from wk 1)	Pivot, XLOOKUP, Power Query, dashboards	Deep	62% of PM JDs; fastest credibility; builds on her pivot/trend base
2	**SQL**	JOINs, subqueries, CTEs, window functions	**Every line**	Her explicit ask; interview insurance
3	**Power BI**	One real end-to-end dashboard	Working	Low JD %, high *portfolio* payoff (visual proof of insight)
4	**Python**	pandas: read/clean/analyze/summarize	**Every line** (1st project), then ship-fast	Hold a BA-level Python conversation
5	**Vibe-coding**	Build small working apps with AI	Ship-fast	Light projects + "I built an app" story

Protective rule: *understand-every-line* for SQL + first Python project (interview insurance). *ship-fast* for everything after.

Where to learn (free/cheap, confirmed in Doc3): mode.com/sql-tutorial, kaggle.com/learn (Python, Pandas, Advanced SQL), StrataScratch (SQL practice), learn.microsoft.com (Power BI), Udemy "100 Days of Code" (Angela Yu) for Python, ExcelJet + Microsoft Learn for Excel.

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6. Track 2 — Portfolio (makes the brand *provable*)

Structure: 3 flagship (deep, full case study, interview centerpieces) + 7 light (vibe-coded / analysis / strategic memo). Target: 10 total.

Sourcing method (the reusable skill):
1. **Public pain points** — earnings calls, Glassdoor, App Store/Play reviews, Reddit, news ("Starbucks mobile-order bottleneck").
2. **Public data** — Kaggle, 10-Ks, CFPB complaints DB, Yelp/App reviews, Inside Airbnb, gov/health datasets.
3. **The JD mirror** — reverse-engineer projects from what target JDs need solved.
4. **Her own scar tissue** — Uber problems she lived (appeals queue, fraud triage, SOP gaps), recreated with public/synthetic data.

Flagship case-study format (consistent across all):

> **Problem** (1–2 sentences, real & public) → **Approach** → **Key finding** (with a number) → **What I built** (SQL/BI/Python) → **Recommendation** *(her insight/strategy layer — the differentiator)* → **What I'd do next.**

Portfolio home: one clean Notion page (or simple site) — About → 3 flagships with big impact numbers → 7 light projects in a grid → resume + LinkedIn links. **Every project ends in a recommendation**, because her edge is the strategy, not the query.

6a. Project idea menu — pick 10 (≈20 options)

Legend: **[F]** flagship-capable · **[L]** light/vibe-coded · **[N]** non-tech/strategy · 🏥 healthcare · skills in *(parens)*.

Retail / dream-company ops
1. **[F] Starbucks mobile-order throughput** — model peak-hour bottlenecks & staffing; recommend a fix. *(Excel/SQL + Power BI)*
2. **[L] IKEA stockout & last-mile delay analysis** — public supply-chain data; where inventory breaks. *(SQL + Power BI)*
3. **[F] Amazon return-fraud triage** — recreate her Uber fraud-triage work on public returns/e-commerce data; prioritization logic. *(SQL + Python)*
4. **[N] Costco vs. competitor inventory-turn strategy memo** — strategic teardown, minimal data. *(strategy + Excel)*

Marketplace / gig / rideshare
5. **[F] Rideshare cancellation-driver analysis** — why riders/drivers cancel; ops levers to reduce it. *(SQL + Python + BI)*
6. **[L] Gig-worker appeals-queue SLA dashboard** — her Uber appeals work, synthetic data, KPI dashboard. *(Excel/Power BI)*

Media / subscription
7. **[F] Spotify (or streaming) churn-driver analysis** — what predicts churn; retention strategy. *(Python + strategy memo)*
8. **[N] Subscription pricing / bundling strategy memo** — pure strategic reasoning + light modeling. *(strategy + Excel)*

Reviews / voice-of-customer (her "reviews sound interesting")
9. **[L] App-store review → product-pain classifier** — vibe-coded; auto-tag reviews into pain themes. *(vibe-coding + Python)*
10. **[L] Yelp/Amazon review sentiment & theme dashboard** — turn unstructured reviews into an ops action list. *(Python + BI)*

Risk / compliance / governance (her DNA → differentiator)
11. **[F] CFPB complaint-pattern risk dashboard** — public complaints DB; spot emerging risk clusters. *(SQL + Power BI)*
12. **[N] AI-governance playbook for a gig platform** — policy + risk framework for safe AI adoption; the risk→AI thesis. *(strategy, non-tech)*
13. **[L] Fraud-pattern detection on public transaction data** — rules + light model; her fraud background. *(SQL + Python)*

Healthcare 🏥 (B.Sc tie-in)
14. **[F] 🏥 ER wait-time / patient no-show reduction** — public hospital data; process-improvement recommendation. *(SQL + Python + BI)*
15. **[L] 🏥 Hospital supply / PPE stockout analysis** — supply-chain lens on health data. *(SQL + Power BI)*
16. **[N] 🏥 Menstrual-health access program design** — ties to her Healing Train Foundation work; program/ops design memo. *(strategy, non-tech)*

Process improvement / ops excellence (Lean Six Sigma tie-in)
17. **[L] Lean Six Sigma DMAIC case on a public process** — apply her certification to a documented real process. *(Excel + process)*
18. **[N] SOP-standardization & escalation-design toolkit** — reusable framework from her Uber SOP work. *(strategy, non-tech)*

Vibe-coded utilities (breadth + "I ship" story)
19. **[L] Personal job-search analytics dashboard** — analyze *this very repo*'s 18.9K-job dataset; meta and impressive. *(SQL + BI + vibe-coding)*
20. **[L] Automated weekly-report / KPI-digest tool** — small app that turns a CSV into a formatted report. *(vibe-coding + Python)*

Recommended default mix if undecided: Flagships = #3 (Amazon fraud), #7 (Spotify churn), #14 (ER healthcare). Light = #6, #9, #11, #12 (AI-gov thesis), #17, #19, #20. Adjust freely.

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7. Track 3 — Consulting fit-test (time-boxed → decision)

Runs **weeks 1–6, ~2 hrs/week**, then a **verdict**. Never competes with PM.
- **Read/watch:** *Case Interview Secrets* (Cosentino) or *Case in Point* + a few "day in the life of a consultant" videos + one McKinsey/BCG problem-solving explainer.
- **Talk:** 2–3 conversations with real consultants (folds into networking — no extra load).
- **Taste:** one practice case with a classmate.
- **Week-6 decision:** *Does the work (variety, research, strategy) excite me enough to prep cases?* → **keep** (add light case prep in Nov) or **drop** (reclaim hours for PM). Either answer is a win.

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8. Track 4 — Networking engine (highest ROI in the plan)

- **2 alumni/coffee chats + 1 event, weekly** — fixed blocks from week 1.
- Build before December: target-company tracker (dream list + 2 contacts each), referral-ask cadence, LinkedIn "Featured" build-out, informational-interview templates (reuse Doc3 templates).
- **Applications stay light until December** (portfolio not ready) — but networking runs hot the whole time so December is not a cold start.

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9. Track 5 — "Edge" extras (shine brighter)

Opportunistic, not mandatory — slot when energy allows:
- **Case competitions** — UW Foster case comps, MBA/grad case challenges, company-sponsored (e.g. supply-chain case comps). Great strategy-muscle + résumé line + team networking.
- **Hackathons** — Devpost "online + supply chain / operations / automation"; look 4–6 weeks out to prep. Pairs with a vibe-coded project.
- **Review paper / professor project** — approach a UW Foster prof about co-authoring or assisting a supply-chain / ops / risk paper. High credibility signal; long lead time so start outreach early.
- **Certifications (optional):** Lean Six Sigma Green Belt upgrade; Google Project Management or PMP exam (she's PMP-trained already — completing it is a strong signal).

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10. Track 6 — Life (protected, not optional)

🔒 **Sat nights** · 🔒 **family calls** · **gym** (habit slots) · **hobby/"magic"** (flexible weekly block until defined). Doc3's Sunday 4-question check-in carries over.

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11. Deliverables produced from this spec

1. **This spec** (career-plan/00-career-map-spec.md) — the strategy of record.
2. **Project picks** — she circles 10 from §6a.
3. **Printable week-by-week calendar** — one standalone page per week, day-by-day, "where to study," depth target, hand-offs; Doc3 visual style; covers Build → Polish → Market. Built *around her 10 picks.*

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12. Open decisions before the calendar is built

- □ Confirm the 10 project picks from §6a (or accept the recommended default mix).
- □ Confirm case-competition / hackathon / paper appetite (which of the §9 extras to actually schedule).
- □ Confirm PMP completion in-scope or defer.

Skills — What to Build, How Deep, and When

← Index

The five-skill build plan, ordered by your own job data. Companion pages: Projects · Networking · Reading · Consulting · Edge.

Read this first — why this order, and what these skills are actually for

I mined the full text of **3,576 real Program/Project Manager job descriptions** from your own scraped database. Here's what those roles actually demand:

Rank	Skill	% of PM JDs
1	Cross-functional	**88%**
2	Communication	**74%**
3	**Risk**	**72%**
4	Stakeholder management	**66%**
5	**Excel**	**62%**
—	SQL	**8%**
—	Power BI / Python	**4% / 2%**

The takeaway that shapes this whole page: the top of the demand list *is your Uber background* — risk, stakeholders, cross-functional work. You already clear those. So the tech skills below (SQL, Power BI, Python, vibe-coding) are **not** here to get you past keyword filters. Your résumé already passes those.

They exist for exactly two reasons:

1. **Portfolio proof** — so "strategic problem-solver" is *shown with a number*, not just claimed.
2. **Interview credibility** — so you can hold a data conversation and say "*I built this.*"

Your depth bar (say it out loud before every study session):

> *Fluent — can build a prototype, understand the data, and turn it into a storyline. Not an engineer. Not a heavy business analyst.*

Excel comes first because it's 62% of JDs and gives you the fastest credibility. Everything after Excel is about turning your strategy into provable projects.

The protective rule (don't skip this)

> **Understand every line for: SQL (all of it) + your FIRST Python project.**
> **Ship-fast for: everything after that.**

Why: SQL and your first real Python analysis are your *interview insurance*. If someone asks "walk me through how you got this number," you must be able to answer without hand-waving. Once you've earned that once, you're allowed to move fast — lean on AI, copy patterns, ship the thing. Depth first, speed second.

The five skills, in order

1. Advanced Excel — *blended with SQL from Week 1*

Depth target	Pivot tables, XLOOKUP, Power Query, clean dashboards
Learn mode	**Deep** (builds on your existing pivot/trend base)
Why first	62% of PM JDs; fastest credibility; you're already partway there
Scheduled	**Weeks 1–3** (schedule)

Resources: ExcelJet (formula reference + quick lessons) · Microsoft Learn — Excel (Power Query, dashboards)

Week-by-week:
- □ **Wk 1** — Pivot tables refresher + XLOOKUP (ExcelJet)
- □ **Wk 2** — Power Query intro (import + shape data)
- □ **Wk 3** — Dashboard basics (turn a table into a one-glance view)

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2. SQL — *the every-line skill*

Depth target	JOINs, subqueries, CTEs, window functions
Learn mode	**Every line** — your explicit ask + interview insurance
Why	Only 8% of JDs list it, but it's the backbone of every data project and the thing interviewers probe
Scheduled	**Weeks 1–6** (blended with Excel, then deepened)

Resources: mode.com/sql-tutorial (primary path) · Kaggle Learn — Advanced SQL (CTEs, window functions) · StrataScratch (real interview-style practice)

Week-by-week:
- □ **Wk 1** — SELECT / WHERE / ORDER BY (mode Basics 1–3)
- □ **Wk 2** — COUNT / SUM / GROUP BY + JOINs start (mode 4)
- □ **Wk 3** — JOINs deep + subqueries (mode 5) + StrataScratch easy ×3
- □ **Wk 4** — Window functions intro (~1 light session — August deload)
- □ **Wk 5** — CTEs + window functions (Kaggle Advanced SQL)
- □ **Wk 6** — Apply SQL to real Starbucks project queries

> After Week 6, SQL becomes a *tool you use* on projects, not a subject you study. You keep it sharp by writing queries for Amazon fraud, rideshare, and the capstone.

3. Power BI — *working, for visual proof*

Depth target	One real, end-to-end dashboard
Learn mode	**Working** (build one well — you don't need mastery)
Why	Low JD % (4%), but *high portfolio payoff* — a live dashboard is visual proof of insight generation, your edge
Scheduled	**Weeks 5–8**

Resources: Microsoft Learn — Power BI (free, official, project-based)

Week-by-week:
- □ **Wk 5** — Power BI intro (Microsoft Learn), start alongside SQL
- □ **Wk 6** — Import data, build 2 visuals (on the Starbucks project)
- □ **Wk 7** — Dashboard formatting, KPI cards, slicers
- □ **Wk 8** — DAX basics (measures, calculated columns) — deload ends here

4. Python — *every line for project #1, then ship-fast*

Depth target	pandas — read, clean, analyze, summarize data
Learn mode	**Every line for your first project**, then **ship-fast**
Why	Only 2% of JDs, but lets you hold a BA-level Python conversation and say "I built this"
Scheduled	**Weeks 9–12**

Resources: Udemy — "100 Days of Code: Python" (Angela Yu) (Days 1–17 is plenty) · Kaggle Learn — Python + Pandas

Week-by-week:
- □ **Wk 9** — Days 1–10: variables, loops, functions *(every line)*
- □ **Wk 10** — Days 11–17: file I/O + pandas + Kaggle Pandas 1–3 *(every line)* — this feeds your first Python flagship, **Amazon return-fraud**
- □ **Wk 11** — pandas deep: groupby, filtering, cleaning *(every line — interview insurance)*
- □ **Wk 12** — finish pandas; optional light intro to a model

> The **Amazon return-fraud** flagship (starts Wk 10) is your designated *understand-every-line* Python project. Once it's shipped, you've earned ship-fast mode for all later Python work.

5. Vibe-coding — *ship-fast, "I build things"*

Depth target	Build small working apps with AI
Learn mode	**Ship-fast** (understand the shape, not every line)
Why	Breadth + an "I shipped a working app" story; pairs with light projects and hackathons
Scheduled	**Weeks 13–14** (then consolidation Wk 15)

Resources: AI coding tools (Claude, Cursor, v0, Replit) — describe what you want, iterate, ship. No formal course; learn by building.

Week-by-week:
- □ **Wk 13** — Build a small app with AI; reuse it for a light project
- □ **Wk 14** — Polish the app; connect the pieces
- □ **Wk 15** — Consolidation — no new skill; apply everything to the rideshare capstone

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At-a-glance calendar

Weeks	Aug deload?	Excel	SQL	Power BI	Python	Vibe
1–3	—	●	●			
4	🟡		○			
5–6	🟡		●	●		
7–8	🟡→			●		
9–12	—		(use)		●	
13–15	—		(use)	(use)	(use)	●

● = actively learning · ○ = light session · (use) = applying it on projects

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Skill → interview talking point

When an interviewer asks about each skill, don't recite a syllabus — tell them what you *built* and what you *found*. Lead with the insight, mention the tool second.

Skill	What to say when asked
Excel	*"It's my daily driver — pivots, XLOOKUP, Power Query. I built the Costco inventory-turn model and every project dashboard starts in Excel before it graduates to Power BI."*
SQL	*"Comfortable end-to-end — JOINs, CTEs, window functions. On the Starbucks throughput project I wrote the queries myself to find the peak-hour bottleneck; happy to walk through the logic."*
Power BI	*"I build dashboards that a stakeholder can read in one glance — KPI cards, slicers, the story on top. The point isn't the chart, it's the decision it drives."*
Python	*"I use pandas to clean and analyze data — I recreated my Uber fraud-triage work on public e-commerce data and can explain every step. I'm fluent, not an engineer, and that's exactly the level the role needs."*
Vibe-coding	*"I ship small tools fast with AI — I built a working app for [project] in a weekend. I care more about solving the problem than writing perfect code, and AI lets me move at the speed of the idea."*

The through-line for all five: *"Tech is how I prove the insight. My edge is framing the real problem and recommending the fix — the code just makes it undeniable."*

Next: turn these skills into proof → Projects. Timeline source of truth → Master Schedule.

Portfolio — Your Proof Engine

← Index

Your edge is **strategy and framing**, not the query. So every project here exists to make one sentence *provable* instead of *claimed*:

> "*Strategic problem-solver who turns messy situations into clear solutions — and brings risk, compliance & governance discipline into operations and into how teams adopt AI safely.*"

The tech (SQL/Python/BI) is only there to (1) **prove** the insight and (2) buy you **interview credibility** so you can say "*I built this.*" Depth bar: **fluent, can build a prototype, understand the data, tell the story — not an engineer.** Every project ends in a **recommendation**, because that's where you win.

Related: Skills · Networking · Reading · Consulting · Edge

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1. The 4-Step Sourcing Method

This is a reusable skill, not a one-time exercise. Find a *real* problem a *real* company has, then solve a slice of it with public data. Four ways in:

Step	What you're hunting	Where to look
1. Public pain points	A problem a company has *said out loud*	**Earnings-call transcripts** (they name their own bottlenecks), **Glassdoor** (employees describe broken processes), **App Store / Play reviews**, **Reddit** (r/uberdrivers, r/starbucksbaristas), news headlines
2. Public data	Numbers to actually analyze	**Kaggle** (search the company/industry), **10-K / annual reports** (inventory turns, margins, risk factors), **CFPB complaints DB** (consumer-finance risk patterns), **Yelp** & App reviews (voice-of-customer), gov/health open data (data.gov, CDC, HHS)
3. The JD mirror	What your target roles need *solved*	Pull 5 real Program/Ops JDs → list the verbs ("reduce cost," "improve throughput," "manage risk") → build the project that demonstrates that verb
4. Your own scar tissue	Problems you already lived at Uber	Appeals queue, fraud triage, SOP gaps, escalation design — recreate with public or synthetic data. **This is your unfair advantage** — you already know the real problem

Rule of thumb: the strongest projects stack two of these — a *named* pain point (Step 1) + *real* data (Step 2). "Starbucks said in their earnings call that mobile-order throughput is a problem" + a public QSR wait-time dataset = a project nobody can wave away.

---

2. The Case-Study Format (use the SAME one every time)

Consistency is a signal. Six beats, always in this order:

1. **Problem** — 1–2 sentences, real and public. *Cite where you found it* (the earnings call, the review, the news).

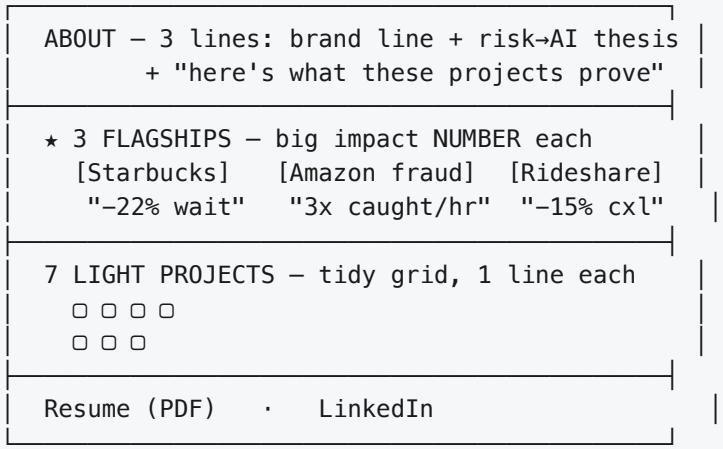
2. **Approach** — how you framed it and what you'd measure. (Your framing = your edge — spend words here.)
3. **Key finding** — one sentence, **with a number.** ("38% of returns flagged came from 6% of accounts.")
4. **What I built** — the SQL / Python / dashboard. Screenshot + link. Keep it short; the build serves the finding.
5. **Recommendation** — **your differentiator.** The specific action you'd take and the projected impact. This is the part hiring managers remember.
6. **What I'd do next** — one honest line on the limitation and the next iteration. Shows maturity, not gaps.

> Print this six-line skeleton and fill it in *before* you write a single query. If you can't state the Problem and the Recommendation-shape up front, you're not ready to build yet.

---

3. Portfolio Layout — One Clean Notion Page

One page. Scannable in 30 seconds. A hiring manager should see the numbers before they scroll.



- **About** — your brand line, the risk→AI thesis, one line on what the work proves.
- **3 flagships up top**, each with a **big number** (the Key finding). These are your interview centerpieces.
- **7 light projects in a grid** — one line + one link each. Breadth and "I ship."
- **Resume + LinkedIn** at the bottom, always linked. Also add this page to LinkedIn **Featured** (Polish, Week 17).

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4. Your 10 Projects

8 locked + 2 open. Flagships marked ★. Two projects (marked 🎯 **risk→AI**) carry your differentiator thesis — they end in a *governance* recommendation, showing you can bring risk discipline into how a team automates a decision with a model.

#	Project	Type	Skills	Weeks	Thesis
17	Lean Six Sigma DMAIC case	Light	Excel + process	**2–3**	
4	Costco inventory-turn strategy memo	Non-tech	Strategy + Excel	**3–4**	
1	★ Starbucks mobile-order throughput	**Flagship**	Excel/SQL + Power BI	**5–8**	
2	IKEA stockout & last-mile delay	Light	SQL + Power BI	**7–8**	
15	🏥 Hospital PPE stockout	Light	SQL + Power BI	**9–10**	
3	★ Amazon return-fraud triage	**Flagship**	SQL + Python	**10–12**	🎯
13	Fraud-pattern detection	Light	SQL + Python	**12–13**	🎯
5	★ Rideshare cancellation (capstone)	**Flagship**	SQL + Python + BI	**13–15**	
A	OPEN slot — your idea	Light	your call	**15**	
B	OPEN slot — your idea	Light	your call	**16**	

Full week-by-week: MASTER-SCHEDULE. Skill build order: Skills.

Project Cards

Each card: **Problem → Data → Skills → Weeks → What the Recommendation must demonstrate.**

#17 · Lean Six Sigma DMAIC case · Light · Weeks 2–3

- **Problem:** Take one documented, real, public process that has waste or defects (e.g., a clinic check-in, a drive-thru line, a returns-handling process) and run a full **Define-Measure-Analyze-Improve-Control** cycle on it.
- **Data:** A publicly documented process (company blog, ASQ / Six Sigma case libraries) + a realistic synthetic cycle-time/defect dataset you build, or a Kaggle call-center / manufacturing-defect dataset.
- **Skills:** Excel (control charts, Pareto), light SQL, DMAIC method.
- **Recommendation must demonstrate:** you can run a **rigorous improvement method end-to-end** and quantify the win — "this change cuts cycle time X%." Cashes in your **Lean Six Sigma Yellow Belt** as your very first published proof (project 1 of 10).

#4 · Costco inventory-turn strategy memo · Non-tech · Weeks 3–4 (deload-friendly)

- **Problem:** Why does Costco's low-SKU, membership model beat competitors on inventory turnover? Strategic teardown vs. Walmart / Target / BJ's.
- **Data: 10-Ks and annual reports** (compute inventory turns and days-inventory yourself from the filings), investor decks, earnings calls.
- **Skills:** Strategy + light Excel (ratios from filings). Almost no code — perfect for the August exam-crunch deload.
- **Recommendation must demonstrate:** business & financial literacy plus **strategic framing** — a crisp recommendation *for a competitor*. This is your core edge (insight, not queries) on full display, and it warms you up for the *Financial Intelligence* book later.

#1 · ★ Starbucks mobile-order throughput · FLAGSHIP · Weeks 5–8

- **Problem:** Mobile-order surges create peak-hour bottlenecks and in-store congestion — a problem **Starbucks has named in its own earnings calls**. Model the peak-hour bottleneck and staffing, then recommend a fix.
- **Data:** Starbucks **earnings-call transcripts** (the pain point in their own words) + a public QSR/restaurant wait-time or foot-traffic dataset (Kaggle) + a synthetic peak-hour order-arrival curve you model.
- **Skills:** Excel/SQL for the analysis, **Power BI** for a peak-hour throughput dashboard.
- **Recommendation must demonstrate:** a concrete **operational lever** (e.g., a dedicated mobile-order handoff station, staggered barista scheduling at peak) with a **projected throughput gain / wait-time cut**. Your first flagship on a dream company — the interview centerpiece that proves you frame a real problem and land a quantified fix (project 3 of 10).

#2 · IKEA stockout & last-mile delay · Light · Weeks 7–8

- **Problem:** Stockouts and last-mile delivery delays erode sales and customer experience — well-documented for IKEA and loud in **App Store / Trustpilot reviews**.
- **Data:** Public retail inventory/demand datasets (Kaggle), IKEA **App Store & Trustpilot reviews**, news; synthetic inventory data where needed.
- **Skills:** SQL + Power BI (deliberately reuses your Starbucks dashboard skills — faster second lap).
- **Recommendation must demonstrate:** *where* inventory breaks and a specific fix — a reorder-point / safety-stock adjustment or a last-mile lever. Shows supply-chain diagnosis on a second dream company.

#15 · 🏥 Hospital PPE stockout · Light · Weeks 9–10

- **Problem:** Hospitals ran out of PPE (masks, gowns) during demand surges. Apply a supply-chain lens to health data and prevent the next stockout.
- **Data:** Public hospital-supply / PPE datasets (data.gov, HHS, CDC), the **CDC PPE Burn-Rate** methodology (public), CMS data; synthetic burn-rate model.
- **Skills:** SQL + Power BI.
- **Recommendation must demonstrate:** a **par-level / buffer-stock or demand-forecast** recommendation that prevents stockout. Doubles as your **healthcare (B.Sc) tie-in** — a differentiated angle most PM candidates can't offer (project 5 of 10, halfway ✅).

#3 · ★ Amazon return-fraud triage · FLAGSHIP · Weeks 10–12 · 🎯 risk→AI

- **Problem:** E-commerce return fraud (wardrobing, empty-box, receipt fraud) costs retailers billions. Amazon must decide *which* returns to investigate. **Recreate your Uber fraud-triage prioritization** on public returns/e-commerce data.
- **Data:** Kaggle e-commerce transactions / returns datasets, public fraud datasets (IEEE-CIS Fraud Detection, credit-card fraud), NRF return-fraud statistics (public), synthetic returns.
- **Skills:** SQL + Python (pandas + a light risk-scoring model).
- **Recommendation must demonstrate — TWO layers:**
  1. **Ops:** a triage rule that maximizes **caught-fraud per investigator-hour.**
  2. 🎯 **Governance (the thesis):** guardrails for *safely automating* this with a model — false-positive/customer-friction thresholds, bias checks, human-in-the-loop, an audit trail. **This is where "I**

bring risk & governance discipline into how teams adopt AI safely" is shown, not claimed. Your scar-tissue flagship (project 6 of 10).

#13 · Fraud-pattern detection · Light · Weeks 12–13 · 🎯 risk→AI

- **Problem:** Detect fraud patterns in transaction data with rules + a light model. A fast spin-off of the Amazon flagship that leans on your fraud background.
- **Data:** Kaggle credit-card fraud dataset, IEEE-CIS, synthetic transactions.
- **Skills:** SQL + Python.
- **Recommendation must demonstrate:** a **rules-plus-model** detection approach **and where to draw the automation line** — precision/recall tradeoff, what to auto-block vs. flag-for-review, model monitoring. **Second project carrying the risk→AI thesis** (project 7 of 10).

#5 · ★ Rideshare cancellation · FLAGSHIP / capstone · Weeks 13–15

- **Problem:** Rider and driver cancellations hurt marketplace liquidity and CX. Why do they cancel, and which ops levers reduce it? **Your own Uber scar tissue** — the most authentic story you have.
- **Data:** Kaggle rideshare/trip datasets (Uber/Lyft/Ola cancellation data), App Store reviews and **Reddit** (r/uberdrivers) for the qualitative "why," synthetic where needed.
- **Skills:** SQL → Python → Power BI, **connected into one end-to-end pipeline** (this is the capstone — it shows the full stack works together).
- **Recommendation must demonstrate:** ops levers to reduce cancellation rate (ETA accuracy, matching radius, surge communication) with a **projected reduction %.** The capstone that proves the whole toolkit + your strategic recommendation in one artifact (project 8 of 10).

OPEN Slots A & B (your own ideas) · Weeks 15–16

Two slots are deliberately yours — pick problems *you* care about (reviews/voice-of-customer, subscription churn, a menstrual-health program design, the meta "analyze this job-search repo" idea — see spec §6a for the full menu). Before you commit a slot, run it through this checklist:

- □ **Real, nameable problem.** Can I point to an earnings call, a review thread, or a news story that says this is broken?
- □ **Public data exists.** Kaggle / 10-K / CFPB / reviews / gov data — or a defensible synthetic set. (Don't pick a problem you can't get numbers for.)
- □ **One number.** Will this produce a single Key-finding number I can put on the portfolio card?
- □ **Ends in a recommendation.** Is there a clear action + projected impact — the part that's *my* edge?
- □ **Right size.** Buildable in ~1 week at ship-fast depth (these are Light, not flagships).
- □ **Adds something new.** A skill, an industry, or the risk→AI thesis I haven't already shown.

If a slot idea checks all six, it's a good project. If it misses "one number" or "ends in a recommendation," reshape it before you start.

Cadence reminder: publish each project the week it finishes, in the six-beat format, to the Notion layout. By Week 16 all 10 are live and the portfolio is ready for Polish. Networking runs the whole time (Networking) so December isn't a cold start.

Networking Engine

← Index

> **Why this page exists:** networking is the single highest-ROI activity in your whole plan. Most jobs are filled through a warm intro, not a portal. Your portfolio proves you *can* do the work — but a person deciding to vouch for you is what gets you in the room. This page is built to be **grabbed and used**: open it, copy a message, fill the `[brackets]`, hit send.

Your one-line intro (use everywhere): "*Process & operations leader who makes things run better and cheaper — I bring risk, compliance & governance discipline into operations.*"

Related pages: Skills · Projects · Reading · Consulting · Edge

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1. The weekly cadence (non-negotiable blocks)

Slot	When	What
Chat #1	Thu (during your 3–4 hr free block)	1 coffee chat / alumni call
Chat #2	Fri	2nd alumni chat *or* a warm-lead call
Event	Fri	1 networking event (Foster mixer, industry meetup, webinar, panel)
1 DM	Mon (before class)	Send 1 new outreach message to keep the pipeline full
Review	Sun (15 min)	Update the tracker below; queue next week's asks

The math: 2 chats/week × ~20 build weeks = **40+ real conversations before you ever apply.** That is why December is *not* a cold start — by then people already know you and are watching for openings.

The rule that makes it work: applications stay light until December (your portfolio isn't ready yet — see Projects) **but networking runs hot the entire time.** Relationships take weeks to warm; skills you can cram. So front-load the slow thing.

Mindset: you're not asking for a job. You're asking to *learn* — about a team, a company, a career path. Curiosity is warm and gets replies. Desperation is cold and gets ignored. Every template below is built on that.

---

2. Copy-paste message templates

> Fill every `[bracket]`. Keep them short — long messages read as work. Send LinkedIn connection notes and short DMs; save the longer versions for email or a message *after* they connect.

Template 1 — Cold alumni outreach (UW Foster)

```
Hi [Name], I'm Bhumika — an incoming UW Foster MSCM student (starting June 2026).
I came from a risk & compliance / operations background at Uber, and I'm exploring
[program management / operations] roles at companies like [Company].

I saw you went through Foster and are now at [Company] — I'd love to hear how that
transition went for you. Would you be open to a quick 15-min chat in the next couple
of weeks? Totally understand if you're heads-down.

Thanks either way — go Huskies!
Bhumika
```

Template 2 — Warm follow-up / no-reply nudge

Send ~5–7 days after no reply. One nudge only — then let it rest.

```
Hi [Name], floating this back up in case it slipped past — totally get how busy things
get. Still would love 15 minutes to hear about your path to [Company / role] whenever
it's convenient. Happy to work entirely around your calendar. Thanks so much!
```

Template 3 — Coffee-chat request (once they've replied / you have a warm lead)

```
Thank you, [Name]! Here are a few windows that work on my end — happy to flex to
whatever's easiest for you:
  • [Day, time]
  • [Day, time]
  • [Day, time]

15–20 minutes is plenty. I can call, Zoom, or grab coffee if you're in Seattle.
Really looking forward to it.
```

Template 4 — Post-chat thank-you

Send within 24 hours. Reference one specific thing — it proves you listened.

```
Hi [Name], thank you so much for the time today — I really valued your perspective on
[specific thing they said, e.g. "how your team scopes a program before kickoff"].

The point about [second specific takeaway] especially stuck with me — I'm going to
[small concrete action you'll take because of it].

I'll keep you posted as I move through my search. Thanks again for being so generous
with your time!
Bhumika
```

Template 5 — Referral ask

Only after a real conversation — never on first contact. This is the Doc3 phrasing.

```
Hi [Name], I really valued our conversation about [Company / team] — it confirmed this
is exactly the kind of work I want to move toward.

I noticed [Company] has an opening for [Role title] ([link]). Given what we talked
about, I think it's a strong fit for my ops + risk background. Would you be comfortable
referring me, or pointing me to the right person on the team? Totally understand if
it's not the right time — no pressure at all.

Either way, thank you — our chat genuinely helped me think about this more clearly.
```

Template 6 — Networking-event follow-up

Send within 48 hours of the event, while they still remember your face.

```
Hi [Name], great to meet you at [event] — I really enjoyed our conversation about
[topic you discussed]. I'd love to stay connected as I dig into [program management /
operations] roles here in Seattle. Sending a connection request now — hope our paths
cross again soon!
```

Template 7 — "Keep me on your radar" note

For strong contacts you can't help right now — keeps the door open for December.

```
Hi [Name], hope you're doing well! Quick update: I've been building out a portfolio of
operations / process-improvement case studies ([portfolio link]) and I'll be actively
interviewing starting this December.

No ask today — just wanted to stay on your radar. If you ever hear of a
[program / project management] opening on your team or nearby, I'd love for you to think
of me. Thanks, [Name] — always great staying in touch!
```

---

3. Target-company tracker

> Pre-seeded with your dream employers + Seattle tier-1. Fill contacts as you find them (see §5), update **Status** each Sunday, and always leave yourself a **Next action** so you never open this cold.
>
> **Status key:** ⬜ Not started · 🟡 Contacted · 🔵 Chatted · 🟢 Referral in motion

Company	Role type	Contact 1	Contact 2	Status	Next action
Starbucks	Program/Ops Mgr				Find 1 Foster alum in HQ ops
IKEA	Supply Chain / Ops				Search alumni in US supply chain
Amazon	TPM / Program Mgr				Find Foster alum in Amazon ops/PM; ask for warm intro
Uber	Ops / Risk (network)				Re-activate 2 ex-colleagues
Spotify	Program Mgr				Find Seattle/remote PM contact
Microsoft	Program Mgr / TPM				Foster alumni search
Costco	Ops / Merch Ops				Issaquah HQ alum search
Boeing	Program Mgr / SCM				Everett/Renton alum search
Nordstrom	Ops / Merch Ops				Seattle HQ alum search
REI	Supply Chain / Ops				Kent DC / HQ contact
T-Mobile	Program Mgr				Bellevue HQ alum search
Expedia	Program / Product Ops				Seattle waterfront HQ contact

Target: 2 named contacts per company by mid-November (Week 19, see Master Schedule).

---

4. Coffee-chat question bank

> Ask 4–6, not all 10. Let it breathe — the best chats go off-script. Save the referral ask for *later* (Template 5), never this call.

1. How did you get into [role/team], and what surprised you most once you were in it?
2. What does a typical week actually look like — where does your time really go?
3. What separates someone who's *good* at this role from someone who's great?
4. What skills or tools does your team lean on most day-to-day? *(listen for Excel/SQL/risk — maps to Skills)*
5. When your team hires, what makes a candidate stand out — beyond the résumé?
6. How is [Company] thinking about [AI adoption / process automation] right now? *(your risk→AI thesis — a great differentiator)*
7. Looking back, what would you tell yourself starting a program/ops career today?
8. What's a problem your team is wrestling with that a fresh set of eyes could help on?
9. Is there anyone else you'd suggest I talk to as I learn about this space?

10. What's the best way to stay in touch — and how can I be useful to *you*?

Pro moves: #4 tells you what to build. #8 can become a portfolio project. #9 doubles your network from one chat. #10 flips the script — offering value is what makes you memorable.

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5. Where to find people (and the small tactics)

UW Foster alumni — your warmest cold audience:
- **LinkedIn Alumni tool** → go to the *University of Washington (Foster School of Business)* page → **Alumni** tab → filter by *Where they work* and *What they do*. Gold for Template 1.
- **Foster Career Services / MSCM program staff** — ask for the alumni directory and any mentor-matching program. Use it.
- **Foster clubs & Slack/Discord** — join the ops/SCM and consulting clubs; current students refer you to recent grads.

LinkedIn "Open to Work":
- Turn it on **for recruiters only** (the private green-ring-off setting), *not* the public banner. Recruiters can find you; hiring managers and your network don't see a "job-seeking" flag. Keeps you looking selective, not searching.

Handshake:
- UW's official recruiting platform — employers who post there *want* students specifically. Set up your profile, follow your target companies, and watch for their on-campus events and info sessions (easy Friday event slots for §1).

Events to fill the Friday slot:
- Foster mixers & info sessions · Seattle ops/supply-chain meetups (Meetup.com) · industry webinars & panels · company info sessions on Handshake · Edge case comps & hackathons (network *and* résumé line).

Two habits that compound:
- **Give before you ask.** Share an article, congratulate a promotion, intro two people. A network you've fed says yes in December.
- **Log every contact the same day** in the §3 tracker. A relationship you don't track is a relationship you'll lose.

Reading List

← Index

You read about **one book a month**, so this is built to be *browsable*, not a marathon. Four priority books are already slotted into your Build weeks (Section A). Everything else is an à-la-carte menu — grab one when you have energy, skip guilt-free when you don't.

How to read for a job search: read for the **one idea you can use this week**, not for completion. If a book gives you one framework you can name in an interview or apply to a project, it did its job — put it down and move on.

Related pages: Skills · Projects · Networking · Consulting · Edge

Section A — ⭐ Priority 4 (read first, scheduled across Build)

One per month, each paired with the projects and skills running the same weeks. Read these in order.

Book	Author	Skill it builds	Why HER specifically	Scheduled
Bulletproof Problem Solving	Conn & McLean	Structured problem-solving — issue trees, hypotheses, "define the real problem before solving it"	This *is* your edge, turned into a repeatable, nameable method. Turns "I'm good at framing problems" into "I use the 7-step problem-solving process." Also fuels your consulting fit-test running the same weeks.	**Wks 1–4**
The Goal	Goldratt	Theory of Constraints — bottleneck thinking, throughput, operations flow	It's the exact mental model behind your **Starbucks throughput flagship** (wks 5–8, same window): find the bottleneck, fix the constraint. Written as a novel — an easy read that fits the August deload. Core to the Ops / Supply Chain goal.	**Wks 5–8**
The Pyramid Principle	Minto	Top-down executive communication — lead with the answer, structure the "why"	Communication shows up in **74%** of PM job descriptions. Your differentiator is the *recommendation* at the end of each case study — this teaches you to package it so leaders act on it. Your Polish-phase STAR answers are meant to be Pyramid-structured.	**Wks 9–12**
Financial Intelligence	Berman & Knight	Business & financial literacy — read a P&L, talk cost, ROI, and budget	Your brand line is "better *and cheaper*." Budget appears in **42%** of PM JDs. This lets you speak cost-savings and ROI credibly in interviews — the language decision-makers respect.	**Wks 13–16**

Section B — Browsable menu (add as energy allows)

No schedule. Pick by which goal you want to feed that month.

Book	Skill it builds	Which goal it serves
Making Things Happen — Berkun	The craft of actually shipping projects — schedules, decisions, herding a team	#1 Program / Project Management (be the decision-maker who owns launch → implementation)
Competing Against Luck — Christensen	Jobs-to-be-Done — why customers "hire" a product; sharper problem framing	Strategic problem-solving + product-minded PM / consulting
Good Strategy Bad Strategy — Rumelt	Telling real strategy from fluff; diagnosing the core challenge	Strategic problem-solving; the consulting fit-test
Weapons of Math Destruction — O'Neil	How algorithms cause harm at scale — risk & fairness literacy	Risk / Governance → **the risk→AI thesis** (your rare, hire-me-now angle)
Never Split the Difference — Voss	Negotiation & influence without authority	Stakeholder management (**66%** of PM JDs) + your December salary negotiation
The Toyota Way — Liker	Lean, continuous improvement, respect-for-people ops culture	Ops / Supply Chain + Process Improvement (your Lean Six Sigma tie-in)

Section C — Already in your 90-Day doc (carryover — don't re-buy)

You already own or listed these. No need to purchase again — pull from the shelf when the moment fits.

- □ **The Effective Executive** — Drucker
- □ **Thinking in Systems** — Meadows
- □ **Crucial Conversations** — Patterson et al.
- □ **The Manager's Path** — Fournier
- □ **Range** — Epstein
- □ **Inspired** — Cagan

> **Reminder:** same rule applies — read for the *one idea you can use this week*, not the whole book.

Consulting — the 6-Week Fit-Test

← Index

What this is: a short, time-boxed experiment (weeks 1–6, ~2 hrs/week) to answer one question — *is consulting worth prepping for, yes or no?* — and then get out of the way. It ends in an explicit **keep-or-drop decision in Week 6**.

Why it's boxed: Consulting is your **#2-ranked direction**, behind Program/Project Management. It is being *tested, not pursued* — so it can never quietly eat the hours that belong to PM. The test is deliberately cheap: reading you'd enjoy anyway, conversations that fold into your networking blocks, and one practice case with a classmate. If the answer is no, you reclaim the hours. If yes, you add *light* case prep in November — after the portfolio is built.

> **The honest framing:** you said the pull is **problem variety + research + strategy**. That *is* what consulting is. So this test is well-aimed — you're checking a real signal, not a fantasy. Either verdict is a win: a clean "no" is as valuable as a "yes" because it removes a distraction.

The test — four cheap inputs

#	Input	What it costs	What it tells you
1	**Read / watch**	~1 hr/wk, wks 1–5	Does the *shape* of the work interest you?
2	**Talk** (2–3 consultants)	folded into networking chats	What's the job *actually* like day-to-day?
3	**Taste** (1 practice case)	~1 hr, wk 4	Does the problem-solving feel *fun* or *forced*?
4	**Decide** (Week 6)	15 min	Keep or drop — on paper, no waffling

1. Read / watch

- **Pick ONE book** (don't read both): *Case Interview Secrets* — Victor Cosentino **OR** *Case in Point* — Marc Cosentino. See Reading. Cosentino's *Case Interview Secrets* is the gentler start.
- You don't need to *finish* it. Read Ch 1–2 first (wk 2), keep going in wk 5 only if it's holding your interest. Losing interest **is data.**
- **Watch 2 "day in the life of a consultant" videos** (wk 1). Search McKinsey / BCG / Bain analyst day-in-the-life on YouTube. Notice your gut reaction to the travel, the pace, the client work.
- **One McKinsey or BCG problem-solving explainer** (wk 1–2). Search "McKinsey 7-step problem solving" or watch a BCG case walkthrough. This pairs perfectly with *Bulletproof Problem Solving* (your Week 1–4 book) — same muscle.

2. Talk — 2–3 consultants (zero extra load)

These are **not** new meetings. Aim 2–3 of your existing weekly coffee chats at people who consult (or used to). Ask them the questions that reading can't answer:
- What does a normal Tuesday actually look like?
- What do you love about it — and what made people you know leave?

- For someone with a risk/compliance + ops background, is there a natural entry lane (e.g. ops/risk-focused consulting)?
- If you had my profile, would you do it again?

3. Taste — 1 practice case (wk 4)

- Do **one** practice case out loud with a classmate (many MSCM cohorts have consulting-curious peers — great networking too).
- Use a case straight from your chosen book. You're not being graded. You're checking one thing: **did structuring the messy problem feel energizing or draining?**

Map to the schedule (weeks 1–6)

From MASTER-SCHEDULE — this is the whole footprint. All of it lives inside the August deload weeks, so it never collides with a flagship build.

Week	Dates	Consulting action (~2 hrs)
1	Jul 13–19	Watch 2 "day in the life" videos + 1 McKinsey/BCG problem-solving explainer
2	Jul 20–26	Read *Case Interview Secrets* Ch 1–2
3	Jul 27–Aug 2	1 conversation with a consultant (via a coffee chat)
4	Aug 3–9	1 practice case with a classmate
5	Aug 10–16	Continue reading *only if still interested*; 1 more consultant chat
6	Aug 17–23	⭐ **DECISION** — run the framework below, log your verdict

---

⭐ Week-6 Decision Framework

Answer these honestly. There are no wrong answers — a clean "no" frees real hours for PM.

- ☐ **The core question:** Does the work — *problem variety, research, structuring strategy* — excite me enough that I'd *want* to spend November evenings prepping cases?
- ☐ **The videos/reading:** Did the day-in-the-life pull me in, or make me tired?
- ☐ **The people:** Did the consultants I spoke to describe a life I want?
- ☐ **The case:** Did the practice case feel like *play* or like *homework*?
- ☐ **The opportunity cost:** Every hour of Nov case prep is an hour *not* spent on PM stories, mocks, and referrals. Is consulting worth that trade?

Score it simply: mostly yeses → **KEEP**. Mixed or mostly noes → **DROP**. Don't overthink; trust the gut signal the test was built to surface.

Verdict	What happens next
✅ **KEEP**	Add *light* case prep to November (Polish phase). PM stays #1 — consulting rides alongside, it does not take over. Revisit Reading for a case-prep cadence.
❌ **DROP**	Reclaim the ~2 hrs/wk. Pour them into PM: Projects, Networking, and story-building. No guilt — you *tested* it, you didn't guess.

> Whichever way it goes, consulting stops being a background "what if" question and becomes a settled decision. That clarity is the real deliverable.

📝 Log your verdict here

Fill this in during your Week 6 (Aug 17–23) Sunday review.

```
Date decided: _____________________

Verdict:   [ ] KEEP    [ ] DROP

The one signal that decided it:
_____________________________________________________________

_____________________________________________________________

If KEEP → my light Nov case-prep plan (e.g. 1 case/week with a peer):
_____________________________________________________________

If DROP → where the reclaimed ~2 hrs/week now go:
_____________________________________________________________
```

Related pages: Reading · Networking · Projects · Skills · Edge

Edge Track — "Shine Brighter"

← Index

This whole page is opportunistic, not mandatory. The core plan — skills, projects, networking — is what gets you hired. Edge moves are bonus shine: a résumé line, a strategy rep, a credibility signal. Do them *only* when they clear the filter at the bottom of this page. If August is heavy or a flagship is slipping, skip all of this guilt-free.

Why bother at all? Each edge move plays directly to your strength — **framing the real problem, then brainstorming the solution** — and gives you a story that isn't "I took a course." It's "I competed / built / co-authored."

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1. Case Competitions

Strategy muscle · résumé line · team networking — all in one weekend.

Your #1 goal is to be the **decision-maker who owns a program**. A case comp is the closest thing to that you can do before you have the job: you get a messy prompt, frame the real problem, and defend a recommendation to judges. That is your edge on display.

Where to find them:

Source	How to look
UW Foster	Ask your program office + MSCM cohort Slack/GroupMe: "Which case comps run this year?" Foster has internal case challenges and sends teams to external ones.
Grad / MBA challenges	Search "[school] MBA case competition 2026" — many accept cross-program grad teams.
Company-sponsored	Search "supply chain case competition" / "operations case challenge" + sponsor names (e.g. large retail, logistics, CPG firms run these).
Cohort teammates	Best comps are team-based — recruit 2–3 classmates. The team *is* the networking.

- □ **Week 2 (Jul 20–26):** research + list any UW Foster / external case comps with their dates → note them in the table below.
- □ Register only if the comp weekend doesn't collide with a flagship deadline (check MASTER-SCHEDULE).

Lead time: most comps open registration 3–6 weeks before the event. Decide early; teams fill up.

Why it helps: a ranked finish (or even a clean submission) is a résumé bullet, forces the exact "problem → recommendation" story you'll tell in interviews, and puts you in a room with recruiters and strong classmates.

---

2. Hackathons

Pairs perfectly with a vibe-coded project — build once, count it twice.

You don't need to be an engineer. In a "supply chain / operations / automation" hackathon your value is **framing the problem and shaping the solution** while AI does the heavy lifting on code. That's the exact bar from skills: *fluent, can build a prototype, make a storyline — not an engineer.*

Devpost method:
1. Go to **devpost.com/hackathons**.
2. Filter: **Online** + status **Upcoming**.
3. Search themes: **"supply chain" · "operations" · "automation" · "logistics" · "AI for good."**
4. Look **4–6 weeks out** so you have prep runway (idea, teammate, rough plan) before the clock starts.

- □ **Week 2:** scan Devpost, note any well-timed online hackathon in the table below.
- □ **Week 8 (Aug 31–Sep 6):** re-check dates; register if one lands in Sep–Oct.
- □ **Week 11 / Week 13:** prep + hack weekend *if* registered (these are the pre-slotted windows in MASTER-SCHEDULE).

Double-dip: the thing you build at a hackathon can become one of your light portfolio projects (great fit for **OPEN slot A/B**). Never build a hackathon project that doesn't also earn a portfolio slot.

---

3. Professor Paper / Research

The highest-credibility edge move — and the one with the longest lead time, so start now.

A UW Foster professor's name attached to your work says something no course certificate can: *a domain expert trusted her to contribute.* For your risk → ops → AI-governance thesis, a research line is pure gold in interviews and on LinkedIn.

How to pick a professor:
1. Browse the **Foster faculty page** for **Operations / Supply Chain Management** and **Information Systems / risk** researchers.
2. Skim 1–2 recent paper titles or abstracts each. Pick the **2–3 whose topics overlap your brand** (supply chain, operations, risk/governance, AI adoption).
3. Favor someone who **teaches a class you're in or will take** — the relationship already has a foothold.

Lead time is long (faculty reply slowly; projects ramp over weeks), so per MASTER-SCHEDULE:
- □ **Week 2 (Jul 20–26):** *draft* the outreach email (template below).
- □ **Week 3 (Jul 27–Aug 2):** *send* it to your top 1–2 professors.

Copy-paste outreach email:

```
Subject: MSCM student interested in your [supply chain / risk / ops] research

Hi Professor [Last Name],

I'm Bhumika Choudhary, a current MSCM student at Foster. Before the program
I spent [X] years at Uber as a Global SME in Risk & Compliance, where I
worked on [fraud triage / SOP design / stakeholder-facing risk programs].

I came across your work on [specific paper / topic], and it connects
directly to what I want to build my career around: bringing risk and
governance discipline into operations — including how teams adopt AI safely.

I'd love to help with a current or upcoming project — literature review,
data cleaning, analysis, or writing support. I'm comfortable with
[Excel / SQL / basic Python] and can commit roughly [3–4] hours a week
this quarter.

Could I grab 15 minutes during your office hours to hear what you're
working on and where I might be useful?

Thank you for your time,
Bhumika Choudhary
[LinkedIn URL] · [phone/email]
```

Tip: send one email per professor, personalized to their actual paper. Never BCC a batch.

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4. Optional Certifications

Only if a specific gap or job posting demands it — otherwise your portfolio is the stronger signal.

Cert	When to say yes	Effort
Lean Six Sigma Green Belt (upgrade from Yellow)	You keep seeing "Green Belt preferred" in target JDs, or you want a credential that pairs with your DMAIC project (#17). Natural next step from what you have.	Medium — self-paced course + exam
Google Project Management (Coursera)	You want a recognizable PM credential fast and a structured refresher on PM fundamentals. Good résumé keyword; light lift.	Low–medium — ~1–2 months part-time
PMP exam	**Deferred — per your call.** You're already PMP-*trained*; sitting the exam is a strong signal but a big time sink. Revisit *after* December if a target role explicitly requires the full credential.	High — not this cycle

Reality check: your data showed PMP appears in only ~19% of PM JDs and certs rarely beat a live portfolio. Treat certs as tie-breakers, not priorities.

When to Say YES to an Edge Opportunity

Run any edge move through this filter. **If it fails even one, decline — protect the core plan.**

- □ **Timing:** it does *not* collide with a flagship deadline or exam week (MASTER-SCHEDULE).

- ☐ **Leverage:** it produces a reusable asset — a résumé line, a portfolio piece, or a real relationship — not just a busy weekend.
- ☐ **On-brand:** it strengthens the story "*strategic problem-solver who brings risk/governance discipline into ops & AI.*"
- ☐ **Energy:** you actually have the bandwidth this week (not stealing from sleep, gym, or family time 🔒).

> **Rule of thumb:** at most **one** active edge move at a time. Core plan first, always. A missed edge opportunity costs nothing; a missed flagship costs you December.

Pre-scheduled edge check-ins (from MASTER-SCHEDULE): Week 2 (research + draft prof email) · Week 3 (send prof email) · Week 8 (register a hackathon/comp if one lands Sep–Oct) · Weeks 11 & 13 (hackathon prep/weekend) · Week 16 (case comp if live).

My Edge Tracker

Fill this in as you research — one row per real opportunity with a date.

Opportunity	Type	Date / deadline	Registered?	Decision
	Case comp / Hackathon / Paper / Cert		☐	
			☐	
			☐	

Related: Skills · Projects · Networking · Reading · Consulting

Master Schedule — the spine (2026-07-13 → 2026-12-27)

This is the source-of-truth timeline. Every weekly page renders one block below. Reference pages (skills, projects, networking, reading, consulting, edge) hold the detail; this says WHEN.

Fixed weekly skeleton (every week)

- **Mon** 🎓 Class 3–9pm → *light only*: 30-min read OR 1 networking DM before class
- **Tue** ✅ free → skills + project, **cap 3–4 hrs** (overflow → Sun)
- **Wed** 🎓 Class 6–9pm → 2–3 hr skills block before class
- **Thu** ✅ free → project + **1 coffee chat**, **cap 3–4 hrs** (overflow → Sun)
- **Fri** ✅ free → skills + **networking event / 2nd chat** + 1 LinkedIn post
- **Sat** 🎓 Class 9–6 · **night OFF** 🔒
- **Sun** ✅ free → Tue/Thu overflow + assignment buffer + **weekly review (15 min)**
- 🔒 always: Sat night, family calls, gym slots (habit-building)

Phase overview

Phase	Weeks	Dates	Hard checkpoint
BUILD	1–16	Jul 13 – Nov 1	Portfolio + skills done by **Oct 31**
↳ August DELOAD	4–7	Aug 3 – Aug 30	~40% lighter (exam crunch)
POLISH	17–20	Nov 2 – Nov 29	Portfolio LIVE, stories + mocks
MARKET	21–24	Nov 30 – Dec 27	Full apply, interview loops

Skill build order (per her job-data analysis)

Excel+SQL blended (wk 1) → SQL deep (every line) → Power BI → Python deep (every line, 1st project) → vibe-coding (ship-fast).

Project slotting (8 locked + 2 open)

- **[F] Flagship** = deep, full case study, interview centerpiece
- **17 Lean Six Sigma DMAIC [L] → wks 2–3 · #4 Costco strategy memo [N] → wks 3–4 (deload-friendly)**
- **#1 Starbucks throughput [F]** → wks 5–8 · #2 IKEA stockout [L] → wks 7–8
- **#15** 🏥 **Hospital PPE stockout [L]** → wks 9–10 · **#3 Amazon return-fraud [F]** → wks 10–12

- **13 Fraud-pattern detection [L] → wks 12–13 · #5 Rideshare cancellation [F] → wks 13–15**

- **OPEN slot A** → wk 15 · **OPEN slot B** → wk 16 (her own ideas)

Book slotting (Priority 4; ~1/month)

Bulletproof Problem Solving (wks 1–4) → The Goal (wks 5–8) → Pyramid Principle (wks 9–12) → Financial Intelligence (wks 13–16) → browsable menu during Polish/Market.

PER-WEEK BLOCKS

Week 1 · Jul 13–19 · BUILD · "Set up the engine"

- **Theme:** Foundations + turn the networking engine ON.
- **Skill:** Excel — pivot tables refresher + XLOOKUP (ExcelJet). SQL — SELECT/WHERE/ORDER BY (mode.com Basics 1–3). *Blend, understand every line.*
- **Project:** none yet — set up GitHub + Notion portfolio shell.
- **Book:** Start *Bulletproof Problem Solving* Ch 1–2.
- **Consulting:** Start fit-test — watch 2 "day in the life of a consultant" videos (consulting).
- **Networking:** Update LinkedIn headline+bio to new brand line. Send alumni msg #1 & #2 (Template 1). Register for 1 event.
- **Edge:** none.
- **Life:** Set gym slots; Sat night off; 1 family call.
- **Sun review:** confirm portfolio shell + LinkedIn live.

Week 2 · Jul 20–26 · BUILD · "First project, real SQL"

- **Skill:** Excel — Power Query intro. SQL — COUNT/SUM/GROUP BY + JOINs start (mode 4). Every line.
- **Project: #17 Lean Six Sigma DMAIC** kickoff — pick a public/documented process, define D-M-A-I-C scope.
- **Book:** *Bulletproof* Ch 3–4.
- **Consulting:** Read *Case Interview Secrets* Ch 1–2.
- **Networking:** 2 chats (aim 1 = a Program Manager). 1 event. LinkedIn post #1 ("I started building…").
- **Edge:** Research UW Foster case comps + Devpost supply-chain/ops hackathons; note dates in edge. Draft professor-paper outreach email.
- **Sun review:** DMAIC scope done? Prof email drafted?

Week 3 · Jul 27–Aug 2 · BUILD · "Finish light project #1"

- **Skill:** SQL — JOINs deep + subqueries (mode 5) + StrataScratch easy ×3. Excel — dashboard basics.
- **Project: #17 DMAIC** finish + write case study (Problem→…→Recommendation). Publish to GitHub+Notion.

- **Project: #4 Costco strategy memo** kickoff (strategy + Excel; low-tech, deload-friendly).
- **Book:** Finish *Bulletproof Problem Solving*.
- **Consulting:** 1 conversation w/ a consultant (via networking).
- **Networking:** 2 chats. 1 event. **Send professor-paper outreach email.**
- **Sun review:** DMAIC live on portfolio (project 1 of 10 ✅).

Week 4 · Aug 3–9 · BUILD · 🟡 DELOAD · "Ship the strategy memo, breathe"

- **Skill:** *Light* — SQL window functions intro only (mode) ~1 session.
- **Project: #4 Costco memo** finish + publish (project 2 of 10 ✅). Strategy-only, no heavy tech — good for exam week.
- **Book:** Start *The Goal* Ch 1–3.
- **Consulting:** 1 practice case with a classmate.
- **Networking:** 2 chats. 1 event (lighter if needed).
- **Life:** protect exam time; skills dialed down.
- **Sun review:** on pace despite crunch?

Week 5 · Aug 10–16 · BUILD · 🟡 DELOAD · "Start flagship #1"

- **Skill:** SQL — CTEs + window functions (kaggle Advanced SQL). Start **Power BI** (learn.microsoft.com intro).
- **Project: #1 Starbucks throughput [FLAGSHIP]** kickoff — find public data (mobile-order/peak-hour), define problem + 5 business questions.
- **Book:** *The Goal* Ch 4–6.
- **Consulting:** Continue reading; 1 more consultant chat.
- **Networking:** 2 chats. 1 event. LinkedIn post #2 (reframe Uber as PM work).
- **Sun review:** Starbucks data loaded + questions written?

Week 6 · Aug 17–23 · BUILD · 🟡 DELOAD · "Consulting DECISION"

- **Skill:** Power BI — import data, build 2 visuals. SQL — apply to Starbucks queries.
- **Project: #1 Starbucks** — write SQL queries 1–3, first Power BI visuals.
- **Book:** *The Goal* Ch 7–9.
- **Consulting:** ⭐ **DECISION** — keep (add light case prep to Nov) or drop (reclaim hours). Record in consulting.
- **Networking:** 2 chats. 1 event.
- **Sun review:** consulting verdict logged.

Week 7 · Aug 24–30 · BUILD · 🟡 DELOAD · "Two projects in flight"

- **Skill:** Power BI — dashboard formatting, KPI cards, slicers.
- **Project: #1 Starbucks** — finish dashboard + queries 4–5. **#2 IKEA stockout [L]** kickoff (SQL + Power BI, reuses Starbucks skills).
- **Book:** *The Goal* Ch 10–12.
- **Networking:** 2 chats. 1 event. LinkedIn post #3.
- **Sun review:** Starbucks dashboard near-done?

Week 8 · Aug 31–Sep 6 · BUILD · "Flagship #1 launches"

- **Skill:** Power BI — DAX basics (measures, calculated columns). Deload ends — back to full pace.
- **Project: #1 Starbucks [F]** finish + full case study + publish (project 3 of 10 ✅). **#2 IKEA** continue.
- **Book:** Finish *The Goal*.
- **Networking:** 2 chats. 1 event. LinkedIn post #4 (Starbucks flagship launch + GitHub link).
- **Edge:** check hackathon/case-comp dates; register if one lands in Sep–Oct.
- **Sun review:** flagship #1 LIVE.

Week 9 · Sep 7–13 · BUILD · "IKEA out, healthcare in, Python begins"

- **Skill: Python** Day 1–10 (Angela Yu / Kaggle Python) — variables, loops, functions. *Every line.*
- **Project: #2 IKEA** finish + publish (project 4 of 10 ✅). **#15** 🏥 **Hospital PPE stockout [L]** kickoff.
- **Book:** Start *The Pyramid Principle* Ch 1–3.
- **Networking:** 2 chats. 1 event.
- **Sun review:** IKEA live; Python Days 1–10 done?

Week 10 · Sep 14–20 · BUILD · "Python + flagship #2 start"

- **Skill: Python** Day 11–17 (file I/O, pandas) + Kaggle Pandas 1–3. Every line.
- **Project: #15** 🏥 **PPE** finish + publish (project 5 of 10 ✅). **#3 Amazon return-fraud [FLAGSHIP]** kickoff — recreate fraud-triage on public e-commerce/returns data.
- **Book:** *Pyramid Principle* Ch 4–6.
- **Networking:** 2 chats. 1 event. LinkedIn post #5.
- **Sun review:** PPE live (5/10 ✅, halfway); Amazon scoped?

Week 11 · Sep 21–27 · BUILD · "Build flagship #2"

- **Skill:** Python — pandas deep (groupby, filtering, clean). Every line (interview insurance).
- **Project: #3 Amazon fraud [F]** — SQL + Python triage logic; first findings.
- **Book:** *Pyramid Principle* Ch 7+.
- **Networking:** 2 chats. 1 event.
- **Edge:** hackathon prep if registered.
- **Sun review:** Amazon triage logic working?

Week 12 · Sep 28–Oct 4 · BUILD · "Flagship #2 launches, fraud spin-off"

- **Skill:** Python — finish pandas; light intro to a model (optional).
- **Project: #3 Amazon fraud [F]** finish + case study + publish (project 6 of 10 ✅). **#13 Fraud-pattern detection [L]** kickoff (reuses Amazon work).
- **Book:** Finish *Pyramid Principle*.
- **Networking:** 2 chats. 1 event. LinkedIn post #6 (flagship #2 launch).
- **Sun review:** flagship #2 LIVE.

Week 13 · Oct 5–11 · BUILD · "Vibe-coding + capstone start"

- **Skill: Vibe-coding** — build a small app with AI (ship-fast, understand the shape). Reuse for a light project.

- **Project: #13 Fraud-pattern** finish + publish (project 7 of 10 ✅). **#5 Rideshare cancellation [FLAGSHIP/capstone]** kickoff — SQL+Python+BI.
- **Book:** Start *Financial Intelligence* Ch 1–3.
- **Networking:** 2 chats. 1 event.
- **Edge:** hackathon weekend if scheduled.
- **Sun review:** capstone scoped?

Week 14 · Oct 12–18 · BUILD · "Build the capstone"

- **Skill:** Vibe-coding — polish the app; connect pieces.
- **Project: #5 Rideshare [F]** — connect SQL → Python → Power BI into one flow. **OPEN slot A** kickoff (her idea).
- **Book:** *Financial Intelligence* Ch 4–6.
- **Networking:** 2 chats. 1 event. LinkedIn post #7.
- **Sun review:** capstone pipeline working end-to-end?

Week 15 · Oct 19–25 · BUILD · "Capstone launches"

- **Skill:** Consolidation — no new skill; apply to projects.
- **Project: #5 Rideshare [F]** finish + full case study + publish (project 8 of 10 ✅). **OPEN slot A** finish (9/10 ✅).
- **Book:** *Financial Intelligence* Ch 7+.
- **Networking:** 2 chats. 1 event.
- **Sun review:** capstone LIVE.

Week 16 · Oct 26–Nov 1 · BUILD · ⭐ "BUILD ENDS — portfolio complete"

- **Skill:** Finish *Financial Intelligence*.
- **Project: OPEN slot B** finish (project 10 of 10 ✅). Polish all 10 case studies to the consistent format.
- **Networking:** 2 chats. 1 event. LinkedIn post #8 (portfolio complete).
- **Edge:** case comp if live.
- **Sun review:** ⭐ **END-OF-BUILD CHECK** — 10 projects live? Excel/SQL/BI/Python credible? 25+ chats done? Portfolio ready for Polish?

Week 17 · Nov 2–8 · POLISH · "Portfolio goes fully LIVE"

- **Focus:** Notion portfolio final layout; toggle public; add to LinkedIn Featured + resume header.
- **Stories:** Write 5 STAR answers (Pyramid-structured) from Uber + projects.
- **Interview:** Mock interview #1 (behavioral + portfolio walkthrough).
- **Consulting:** case prep IF kept.
- **Networking:** 2 chats. 1 event. Ask 2 contacts for referrals.
- **Book:** browsable menu — start one (e.g. *Making Things Happen*).
- **Sun review:** portfolio public + linked everywhere?

Week 18 · Nov 9–15 · POLISH · "Sharpen the story"

- **Focus:** Resume final rewrite (every bullet PM/ops language). Portfolio walkthrough script.

- **Stories:** 5 more STAR answers. Record yourself; watch back once.
- **Interview:** Mock #2.
- **Networking:** 2 chats. 1 event. 2 referral asks.
- **Sun review:** resume final?

Week 19 · Nov 16–22 · POLISH · "Company-target the pipeline"

- **Focus:** Target-company tracker (dream list + 2 contacts each). Tailor 3 master résumé variants (PM / Ops / Risk).
- **Interview:** Mock #3 (company-specific).
- **Networking:** 2 chats. 1 event. Convert referral asks.
- **Sun review:** tracker built, variants ready?

Week 20 · Nov 23–29 · POLISH · "Ready to launch"

- **Focus:** Dry-run 5 applications (don't submit yet). Final portfolio + resume QA.
- **Interview:** Mock #4.
- **Networking:** 2 chats. 1 event.
- **Life:** rest before December sprint.
- **Sun review:** ⭐ **POLISH CHECK** — portfolio live, stories sharp, 4 mocks done, tracker ready, referrals in motion.

Week 21 · Nov 30–Dec 6 · MARKET · "Hit the market"

- **Apply:** 5 tailored applications (dream + target companies). Use find-jobs pipeline for fresh listings.
- **Networking:** 2 chats. 1 event. Ask contacts to flag openings.
- **Interview:** prep for any early responses.
- **Sun review:** 5 quality apps in.

Week 22 · Dec 7–13 · MARKET · "Ramp applications"

- **Apply:** 5 more (total 10). Follow up on week-21 apps.
- **Networking:** 2 chats. Direct referral asks at target companies.
- **Interview:** loops beginning — prep per company.
- **Sun review:** any movement?

Week 23 · Dec 14–20 · MARKET · "Interview mode"

- **Apply:** 5 more (total 15+).
- **Interview:** active loops — company-specific prep, portfolio walkthroughs.
- **Networking:** 2 chats. Check in with contacts.
- **Sun review:** interview loops live?

Week 24 · Dec 21–27 · MARKET · "Reflect + sustain"

- **Apply:** 5 more (total 20+).
- **Interview:** continue loops.
- **Reflect:** what's working; adjust for January.

- **Ongoing cadence after this:** 2 apps/day + 2 chats/week + 1 book/month until landed.
- **Sun review:** ⭐ **YEAR-END CHECK** — 20+ apps, interview loops in motion, portfolio doing the talking.

Week 1 · Jul 13–19 · BUILD — "Set up the engine"

← Index

🎯 **This week's mission:** Turn the networking engine ON and lay the foundation — rebrand LinkedIn, stand up the portfolio shell, blend your first Excel + SQL, and get two alumni messages out the door.

> This is a setup week. Nothing here is heavy — you're building the rails everything else runs on. Do the small things fully and you'll feel the momentum by Sunday.

Day-by-day

Day	Status	What to do
Mon	🎓 Class 3–9pm	*Light only.* Read **Bulletproof Problem Solving Ch 1** (~30 min) before class.
Tue	✅ Free (3–4 hr)	**Excel** — pivot-table refresher + XLOOKUP on ExcelJet (~1.5 hr, understand every line). Then **set up the portfolio shell**: create the GitHub repo + a clean Notion page with sections *About* → *Flagships* → *Light projects* → *Resume* + *LinkedIn*.
Wed	🎓 Class 6–9pm	2–3 hr block before class: **SQL** — mode.com SQL Tutorial *Basics 1–3* (SELECT / WHERE / ORDER BY). Understand every line.
Thu	✅ Free (3–4 hr)	**Update LinkedIn** headline + bio to the new brand line + thesis. **Send alumni msg #1** (Template 1) — book your first coffee chat. Drop the brand line + thesis into the Notion **About** section.
Fri	✅ Free	**Send alumni msg #2** (Template 1). **Register for 1 networking event.** Watch **consulting video #1** ("day in the life of a consultant"). SQL/Excel catch-up if behind. *(No LinkedIn post required yet — your first post is Week 2.)*
Sat	🎓 Class 9–6 · night OFF 🔒	No work after class. Take the night. **1 family call.**
Sun	✅ Free	Tue/Thu overflow + assignment buffer. Read **Bulletproof Ch 2**. Watch **consulting video #2**. **Weekly review (15 min).**

📚 Where to study / resources this week

- **Excel** — ExcelJet (pivot tables, XLOOKUP) → detail in Skills
- **SQL** — mode.com/sql-tutorial, *Basics 1–3* → Skills
- **Portfolio shell** — GitHub repo + Notion page → structure in Projects
- **Networking** — Template 1 outreach message → Networking
- **Book** — *Bulletproof Problem Solving* Ch 1–2 → Reading
- **Consulting** — 2 "day in the life of a consultant" videos → Consulting

✅ Done by Sunday

- □ LinkedIn headline + bio rewritten to the brand line + thesis
- □ GitHub repo created + Notion portfolio shell live (empty but structured)
- □ Excel pivot tables + XLOOKUP refreshed (ExcelJet)
- □ SQL mode.com *Basics 1–3* complete (SELECT / WHERE / ORDER BY)
- □ Alumni msg #1 & #2 sent (Template 1)
- □ 1 networking event registered
- □ 2 "day in the life of a consultant" videos watched
- □ *Bulletproof Problem Solving* Ch 1–2 read
- □ Gym slots blocked in calendar · Sat night off · 1 family call done
- □ **Weekly review:** *Is the portfolio shell live and is LinkedIn showing the new brand?*

Index · Week 2 →

Week 2 · Jul 20–26 · BUILD — "First project, real SQL"

← Index

> 🎯 **This week's mission:** Kick off your first portfolio project (Lean Six Sigma DMAIC) and start writing real SQL — while landing your first Program Manager coffee chat.

Day by day

Day	Status	What to do
Mon	🎓 Class 3–9pm	**Light only.** Pick one: 30-min read of *Bulletproof* Ch 3, **or** send 1 networking DM to line up this week's 2 chats.
Tue	✅ Free (cap 3–4 hrs)	**SQL** — COUNT / SUM / GROUP BY (mode lesson 4), *every line*. **Project #17 DMAIC kickoff** — pick a public/documented process; write the **Define** scope (problem, goal, boundaries).
Wed	🎓 Class 6–9pm	**2–3 hr block before class. Excel** — Power Query intro: import a messy file and shape it. Finish *Bulletproof* Ch 4.
Thu	✅ Free (cap 3–4 hrs)	**Project #17 DMAIC** — draft **Measure + Analyze** scope (what data/metrics, where the waste is). **Coffee chat #1** — aim for a Program Manager.
Fri	✅ Free	**SQL** — JOINs start (mode 4), *every line*. **Networking event or 2nd chat. LinkedIn post #1** — "I started building…". **Edge:** research UW Foster case comps + Devpost supply-chain/ops hackathons; log dates in Edge.
Sat	🎓 Class 9–6 · **night OFF** 🔒	No work after class. Rest — you earned it.
Sun	✅ Free	Tue/Thu overflow + assignment buffer. **Edge:** draft the **professor-paper outreach email**. **Consulting:** read *Case Interview Secrets* Ch 1–2. **Weekly review (15 min).**

📚 Where to study / resources this week

- **SQL** → mode.com/sql-tutorial, Lesson 4 (aggregates + intro JOINs). Depth: *every line.* → Skills
- **Excel** → ExcelJet + Microsoft Learn — Excel for Power Query. → Skills
- **Project #17 DMAIC** → format + sourcing method in Projects.
- **Book** → *Bulletproof Problem Solving* Ch 3–4. → Reading
- **Consulting** → *Case Interview Secrets* Ch 1–2 (fit-test, weeks 1–6). → Consulting
- **Networking templates** → Networking.

✅ Done by Sunday

- □ DMAIC process **picked** + full **D-M-A-I-C scope** written (Define → Analyze in detail, Improve/Control sketched)
- □ SQL: COUNT / SUM / GROUP BY done **and** JOINs started (mode 4), understood line by line
- □ Excel: Power Query intro — imported + shaped one file
- □ *Bulletproof* Ch 3–4 read
- □ *Case Interview Secrets* Ch 1–2 read
- □ **2 coffee chats** done (1 with a Program Manager) + **1 event**
- □ **LinkedIn post #1** published ("I started building…")
- □ Case comps + Devpost hackathon dates logged in Edge
- □ **Professor-paper outreach email drafted**
- □ Sunday review (15 min) — **DMAIC scope done? Prof email drafted?**

This is your first real build week — pick a process you actually find interesting for the DMAIC, and it'll carry itself. Framing the problem is your superpower; let it show.

← Week 1 · Index · Week 3 →

Week 3 · Jul 27–Aug 2 · BUILD — "Finish light project #1"

← Index

🎯 **This week's mission:** Ship your first portfolio project — take the Lean Six Sigma DMAIC case all the way to a published case study (1 of 10 live), and open the Costco memo before deload starts.

Day	Status	What to do
Mon	🎓 Class 3–9pm	*Light only.* 30 min reading — finish **Bulletproof Problem Solving** OR fire off 1 networking DM before class.
Tue	✅ Free (cap 3–4 hrs)	**SQL:** mode.com lesson 5 — JOINs deep + subqueries. **Project:** start writing the #17 DMAIC case study (Problem → Approach → Finding → What I built → Recommendation → Next).
Wed	🎓 Class 6–9pm	2–3 hr block before class: **Excel dashboard basics** (ExcelJet / MS Learn) + **3 easy StrataScratch** SQL problems.
Thu	✅ Free (cap 3–4 hrs)	**Project:** finish #17 DMAIC + **publish to GitHub + Notion**. **1 coffee chat** — aim to make this your consulting conversation (fit-test). Overflow → Sun.
Fri	✅ Free	**Project:** kick off **#4 Costco strategy memo** (strategy + Excel, low-tech — sets you up for deload). **Send the professor-paper outreach email.** Networking event OR 2nd chat. 1 LinkedIn post (DMAIC launch).
Sat	🎓 Class 9–6 · **night OFF** 🔒	No work after class. Family call / recharge.
Sun	✅ Free	Tue/Thu overflow + assignment buffer. Finish the book if not done. **Weekly review (15 min).**

📚 Where to study / resources this week

- **SQL** → mode.com SQL Tutorial lesson 5 (JOINs + subqueries) · StrataScratch easy ×3 — details in Skills.
- **Excel** → ExcelJet + Microsoft Learn, dashboard basics.
- **Project #17 (DMAIC) + #4 (Costco memo)** → format & data sources in Projects.
- **Book** → finish *Bulletproof Problem Solving* — see Reading.
- **Consulting chat** → questions to ask in Consulting. Chat logistics in Networking.

✅ Done by Sunday

- ☐ #17 DMAIC case study written (Problem → … → Recommendation → Next)
- ☐ **DMAIC published to GitHub + Notion — project 1 of 10 live** 🎉
- ☐ #4 Costco strategy memo kicked off (scope + outline)
- ☐ SQL: mode lesson 5 done + 3 StrataScratch easy
- ☐ Excel dashboard basics practiced

- ☐ Finished *Bulletproof Problem Solving*
- ☐ 2 coffee chats (1 = a consultant) + 1 event
- ☐ **Professor-paper outreach email SENT**
- ☐ 1 LinkedIn post
- ☐ **Sun review:** DMAIC live on portfolio (project 1 of 10 ✅)?

First one out the door is the hardest — once #17 is live, the rest have a template to follow. Publish it even if it's not perfect.

← Week 2 · Index · Week 4 →

Week 4 · Aug 3–9 · BUILD (🟡 DELOAD) — "Ship the strategy memo, breathe"

← Index

> 🟡 **DELOAD WEEK.** Load is intentionally ~40% lighter this week for exam crunch. This is by design, not falling behind. Skills are dialed down to a single light session; the project is strategy-only (no heavy tech). Protect your exam time first — everything here fits *around* it.

🎯 **This week's mission:** Finish and publish the **Costco strategy memo** (project 2 of 10 ✅) — a low-tech, high-insight win that shows off your real edge — while keeping the exam week calm.

Day-by-day

Day	Status	What to do
Mon	🎓 Class 3–9pm	*Light only.* Read *The Goal* Ch 1 (30 min) **or** send 1 networking DM before class. That's it — rest for class.
Tue	✅ Free (cap 3–4 hrs, keep it light)	**#4 Costco memo** — build the core analysis: inventory-turn comparison vs. a competitor, pull the 2–3 numbers that carry the argument. Strategy + light Excel only.
Wed	🎓 Class 6–9pm	2 hr block before class: **SQL window functions intro** (mode.com, ~1 session). This is the *only* new skill this week — one pass, understand it, move on.
Thu	✅ Free (cap 3–4 hrs)	**#4 Costco memo** — write the **Recommendation** (your insight layer — the whole point) + "What I'd do next." Then **coffee chat #1**.
Fri	✅ Free	**Finish + PUBLISH the Costco memo** to GitHub + Notion (2/10 ✅). Attend **1 networking event** (lighter is fine) or **2nd chat**. Optional light LinkedIn share if energy allows.
Sat	🎓 Class 9–6 · night OFF 🔒	No work after class. Recharge.
Sun	✅ Free	**Consulting: 1 practice case with a classmate** (low-stakes, fun). *The Goal* Ch 2–3 if fresh. Exam/assignment buffer. **Weekly review (15 min).**

📚 Where to study / resources this week

- **SQL (light):** window functions intro — mode.com/sql-tutorial. One session only. Detail → ../01-skills.md.
- **Project #4 Costco memo:** strategy teardown, minimal data — format is Problem → Approach → Finding → Recommendation → Next. See ../02-projects.md.
- **Book:** *The Goal* Ch 1–3 → ../04-reading-list.md.
- **Consulting fit-test:** practice case guide → ../05-consulting.md.
- **Networking templates & tracker:** ../03-networking.md.

✅ Done by Sunday

- ☐ **Costco strategy memo finished + published** (GitHub + Notion) — project 2 of 10 ✅
- ☐ Memo ends in a clear **Recommendation** (your strategy layer, with a number)
- ☐ SQL window functions — 1 intro session done
- ☐ *The Goal* Ch 1–3 read
- ☐ 1 practice case with a classmate done
- ☐ 2 coffee chats + 1 event (lighter OK)
- ☐ Weekly review — **On pace despite the crunch?**

← Week 3 · Index · Week 5 →

Week 5 · Aug 10–16 · BUILD (🟡 DELOAD) — Start flagship #1

← Index

> 🟡 **DELOAD WEEK.** August is intentionally ~40% lighter for exam crunch. Protect study time. If a task slips, that's the plan working — carry it to Sunday. Don't red-line.

🎯 **This week's mission:** Kick off your first flagship — **Starbucks mobile-order throughput** — by finding real public data and writing the 5 business questions that will drive it. Learn just enough SQL (CTEs + windows) and open Power BI.

Day-by-day

Day	Status	What to do
Mon	🎓 Class 3–9pm	*Light only.* Read *The Goal* Ch 4 (30 min) **or** send 1 networking DM before class. Don't stack more — you have class till 9.
Tue	✅ Free (cap 3–4h)	**Skill:** SQL — CTEs + window functions on Kaggle Advanced SQL. **Project:** Start #1 Starbucks — hunt for public mobile-order / peak-hour data.
Wed	🎓 Class 6–9pm	*2–3 hr block before class.* **Skill:** Start **Power BI** — the learn.microsoft.com intro. Just install it and follow the first "load + chart" walkthrough.
Thu	✅ Free (cap 3–4h)	**Project:** Write the Starbucks problem statement + draft your **5 business questions**. **Coffee chat #1** — aim for a consultant (doubles as this week's consulting chat).
Fri	✅ Free	**Skill:** Finish loading the Starbucks dataset. **Networking:** attend 1 event + 2nd chat. **LinkedIn post #2** — reframe your Uber work as program/project management.
Sat	🎓 Class 9–6 · night OFF 🔒	Class all day. No work tonight — rest.
Sun	✅ Free	Overflow: polish the 5 questions if unfinished. Read *The Goal* Ch 5–6. Assignment buffer. **Weekly review (15 min).**

📚 Where to study / resources this week

- **SQL (CTEs + window functions):** Kaggle *Advanced SQL* course — see Skills for the link and depth target ("every line").
- **Power BI (first touch):** learn.microsoft.com Power BI intro — just get it installed and load one dataset.
- **Project #1 Starbucks:** sourcing method + case-study format in Projects. Look for public mobile-order, peak-hour, or store-ops data (Kaggle, news, earnings-call notes).
- **Book:** *The Goal* Ch 4–6 — see Reading.
- **Consulting:** continue your reading + log the chat in Consulting.

✅ Done by Sunday

- □ SQL: completed CTEs + window functions (Kaggle Advanced SQL)
- □ Power BI installed + first walkthrough done
- □ Starbucks public dataset **loaded**
- □ Starbucks **problem statement + 5 business questions** written
- □ *The Goal* Ch 4–6 read
- □ 2 coffee chats done (1 = a consultant) + 1 event attended
- □ LinkedIn post #2 published (Uber → PM reframe)
- □ **Sun review:** *Starbucks data loaded + questions written?*

← Week 4 · Index · Week 6 →

Week 6 · Aug 17–23 · BUILD (🟡 Deload) — Consulting DECISION

← Index

> 🟡 **DELOAD WEEK (Aug 3–30).** Load is intentionally ~40% lighter for exam crunch. Protect study time — if something slips, it slips. Staying on the field beats burning out.

🎯 **This week's mission:** Make the ⭐ consulting call once and for all, and push flagship #1 (Starbucks) forward with your first real Power BI visuals.

⭐ THE DECISION (log it by Sunday)

You've spent weeks 1–6 fit-testing consulting (~2 hrs/wk: reading, videos, consultant chats, one practice case). Now decide — either answer is a win:

"Does the work — variety, research, strategy — excite me enough to prep cases?"
- ✅ **KEEP** → add light case prep in November. PM stays #1 either way.
- ❌ **DROP** → reclaim those hours for portfolio + PM.

→ Write the verdict + one-line why in Consulting.

Day-by-day

Day	Status	What to do
Mon	🎓 Class 3–9pm	*Light only.* 30-min read: *The Goal* Ch 7 — OR send 1 networking DM if you'd rather.
Tue	✅ Cap 3–4 hrs	**Power BI:** import your Starbucks dataset + build visual #1. **SQL:** write Starbucks query #1. → Skills · Projects
Wed	🎓 Class 6–9pm	2–3 hr block before class: **SQL** — Starbucks queries #2 and #3 (apply CTEs/windows from wk 5).
Thu	✅ Cap 3–4 hrs	**Power BI:** build visual #2. **Coffee chat #1** — if you can, make it a consultant, to sharpen the decision.
Fri	✅	**Power BI:** clean up both visuals. **Networking event OR 2nd chat.** (No LinkedIn post required this week — deload; post if it's easy.)
Sat	🎓 Class 9–6 · 🔒 night OFF	No work after class. Rest.
Sun	✅	Overflow (finish queries/visuals) + assignment buffer. Read *The Goal* Ch 8–9. **Log the ⭐ consulting verdict.** 15-min weekly review.

📚 Where to study / resources this week

- **Power BI** — learn.microsoft.com intro (import data → build 2 visuals). Detail: Skills
- **SQL** — apply your CTE/window skills to the Starbucks questions you wrote in wk 5. Practice: StrataScratch if you have spare minutes.
- **Project** — #1 Starbucks throughput [FLAGSHIP]. Format + steps: Projects
- **Book** — *The Goal* Ch 7–9. Reading
- **Consulting** — the decision framework + where to log it: Consulting
- **Networking** — chat templates + event ideas: Networking

✅ Done by Sunday

- □ Power BI: 2 Starbucks visuals built
- □ SQL: Starbucks queries 1–3 written and running
- □ 2 coffee chats + 1 networking event done
- □ *The Goal* Ch 7–9 read
- □ ⭐ **Consulting DECISION made and logged** in Consulting
- □ **Sun review question:** Consulting verdict logged?

← Week 5 · Index · Week 7 →

Week 7 · Aug 24–30 · BUILD — Two projects in flight

← Index

> 🟡 **DELOAD WEEK (Aug 4–7 block).** Load is intentionally ~40% lighter for exam crunch. Protect study time — if something slips, it slips to Sunday, not into your sleep. The plan *expects* this.

🎯 **This week's mission:** Get the Starbucks flagship dashboard near-done and quietly open IKEA — reusing the exact Power BI skills you just built.

Day-by-day

Day	Status	What to do
Mon	🎓 Class 3–9pm	*Light only.* 30-min read: *The Goal* Ch 10–12 **or** send 1 networking DM before class.
Tue	✅ Free (cap 3–4 hrs)	**Power BI:** dashboard formatting + KPI cards (Skills). Apply to **#1 Starbucks** — lay out the dashboard shell + first KPI cards.
Wed	🎓 Class 6–9pm	2–3 hr morning block: **Power BI slicers** + write **Starbucks queries 4–5** (Projects).
Thu	✅ Free (cap 3–4 hrs)	**#1 Starbucks** — wire queries 4–5 into the dashboard. ☕ **Coffee chat #1** (aim: a Program/Project Manager).
Fri	✅ Free	**#2 IKEA stockout kickoff** — find public supply-chain data, define the problem + questions (reuses Starbucks SQL+BI). **Networking event / 2nd chat. LinkedIn post #3.**
Sat	🎓 Class 9–6 · 🔒 night OFF	No work after class. Rest — you earned it.
Sun	✅ Free	Tue/Thu overflow + assignment buffer. Finish Starbucks dashboard polish, tidy IKEA scope. **Weekly review (15 min).**

📚 Where to study / resources this week

- **Skill — Power BI (formatting, KPI cards, slicers):** learn.microsoft.com Power BI intro path → detail in Skills.
- **Projects — Starbucks (finish) + IKEA (kickoff):** case-study format + data-sourcing method in Projects.
- **Book — *The Goal* Ch 10–12:** see Reading.
- **Networking — 2 chats + 1 event + post #3:** templates + target list in Networking.

✅ Done by Sunday

- ☐ Power BI: formatting + KPI cards + slicers practiced
- ☐ #1 Starbucks — dashboard built, queries 4–5 written and wired in
- ☐ #2 IKEA — data found, problem + questions defined (kickoff done)
- ☐ *The Goal* Ch 10–12 read

- □ 2 coffee chats + 1 networking event
- □ LinkedIn post #3 published
- □ Weekly review: **Is the Starbucks dashboard near-done?**

You're steering two projects at once now — that *is* the PM muscle. Keep it light, keep it moving.

← Week 6 · Index · Week 8 →

← Index

Week 8 · Aug 31–Sep 6 · BUILD — Flagship #1 launches

🎯 **This week's mission:** Ship your first flagship. Starbucks goes LIVE with a full case study — your first real interview centerpiece. Deload is over; you're back to full pace and it shows.

Day	Status	What to do
Mon Aug 31	🎓 Class 3–9pm	*Light only.* 30-min read of *The Goal* (you finish it this week) **or** 1 networking DM before class.
Tue Sep 1	✅ Free (cap 3–4 hrs)	**Power BI — DAX basics** (measures + calculated columns) on learn.microsoft.com → apply straight to your Starbucks dashboard. Tighten queries 4–5.
Wed Sep 2	🎓 Class 6–9pm	2–3 hr block before class: build Starbucks DAX measures — peak-hour throughput, staffing-gap KPI cards. Dashboard near-final.
Thu Sep 3	✅ Free (cap 3–4 hrs)	Write the **Starbucks case study**: Problem → Approach → Key finding (with a number) → What I built → **Recommendation** → What I'd do next. **Coffee chat #1** (aim: a Program/Project Manager).
Fri Sep 4	✅ Free	**Publish Starbucks flagship** to GitHub + Notion (project 3 of 10 ✅). **LinkedIn post #4** — flagship launch + GitHub link. Networking event **or** 2nd chat. Check hackathon/case-comp dates → register if one lands Sep–Oct.
Sat Sep 5	🎓 Class 9–6 · night OFF 🔒	No work after class. Rest — you earned it.
Sun Sep 6	✅ Free	Tue/Thu overflow + assignment buffer. Continue **#2 IKEA** (data + queries). Finish *The Goal*. **Weekly review (15 min).**

📚 Where to study / resources this week

- **Power BI — DAX:** learn.microsoft.com Power BI path (DAX measures & calculated columns) → detail in Skills.
- **Starbucks flagship** format & publishing checklist → Projects.
- **Book:** finish *The Goal* → Reading.
- **Chats + post + event** cadence & templates → Networking.
- **Hackathon / case-comp dates** → Edge.

✅ Done by Sunday

- ☐ Power BI DAX basics learned (measures + calculated columns), applied to Starbucks
- ☐ **#1 Starbucks [F]** finished + full case study written + **published to GitHub + Notion** (project 3 of 10 ✅)
- ☐ LinkedIn post #4 live (Starbucks launch + GitHub link)
- ☐ 2 coffee chats + 1 event done
- ☐ #2 IKEA continued

- □ *The Goal* finished
- □ Hackathon/case-comp dates checked; registered if one lands Sep–Oct
- □ **Sun review:** Is flagship #1 LIVE? ⭐

← Week 7 · Index · Week 9 →

Week 9 · Sep 7–13 · BUILD — "IKEA out, healthcare in, Python begins"

← Index

🎯 **This week's mission:** Ship IKEA (project **4 of 10** — halfway is in sight) and write your first real code. Python Days 1–10, every line — this is your interview-insurance skill.

Day	Status	What to do
Mon	🎓 Class 3–9pm · *light only*	Before class: 30-min read — start **The Pyramid Principle Ch 1**. (Or send 1 networking DM instead.)
Tue	✅ free · cap 3–4 hrs	**Python Days 1–4** (variables, loops) — every line. Then push **IKEA**: finalize SQL + Power BI visuals so it's ready to write up.
Wed	🎓 Class 6–9pm	2–3 hr morning block: **Python Days 5–7** (functions).
Thu	✅ free · cap 3–4 hrs	Finish **IKEA** case study (Problem → Approach → Finding → What I built → **Recommendation**) + publish to GitHub + Notion → **project 4/10** ✅. + **1 coffee chat** (aim: a Program Manager or ops person).
Fri	✅ free	**Python Days 8–10** (wrap fundamentals). + **Networking event / 2nd chat**. + **LinkedIn post**: IKEA stockout launch + link.
Sat	🎓 Class 9–6 · night OFF 🔒	Class only. No work after — family / rest.
Sun	✅ free	**Overflow + kickoff:** start **#15** 🏥 **Hospital PPE stockout [L]** — find public health-supply data, define problem + 5 questions. **Pyramid Principle Ch 2–3.** Assignment buffer. **Weekly review (15 min).**

📚 Where to study / resources this week

- **Python (Days 1–10):** Angela Yu "*100 Days of Code*" Days 1–10, or Kaggle → Python course. Understand **every line** — details in Skills.
- **IKEA publish (SQL + Power BI):** case-study format + portfolio home in Projects.
- **#15 Hospital PPE kickoff:** sourcing method (public data + JD mirror) in Projects.
- **Book — The Pyramid Principle Ch 1–3:** Reading list.
- **Chats + event cadence:** templates in Networking.

✅ Done by Sunday

- ☐ **IKEA stockout** finished + published — **project 4 of 10** ✅
- ☐ **Python Days 1–10** complete (every line)
- ☐ **#15** 🏥 **Hospital PPE stockout** scoped (data found + questions written)
- ☐ **The Pyramid Principle Ch 1–3** read

- □ **2 coffee chats + 1 event** done
- □ **1 LinkedIn post** live
- □ **Weekly review:** *IKEA live? Python Days 1–10 done?*

← Week 8 · Index · Week 10 →

Week 10 · Sep 14–20 · BUILD — "Python + flagship #2 start"

← Index

🎯 **This week's mission:** Ship the PPE project (your **halfway** marker — 5 of 10 live), start pandas for real, and scope Amazon fraud.

Day	Status	What to do
Mon	🎓 Class 3–9pm	*Light only.* 30-min read: *Pyramid Principle* Ch 4. OR fire off 1 networking DM before class.
Tue	✅ (cap 3–4 hrs)	**Python Day 11–14** (file I/O) — every line. Then push **#15** 🏥 **PPE** analysis toward done.
Wed	🎓 Class 6–9pm	2–3 hr block before class: **Python Day 15–17** (pandas intro) + **Kaggle Pandas 1–3**. Every line.
Thu	✅ (cap 3–4 hrs)	Finish **#15 PPE** analysis + write the case study (Problem→…→**Recommendation**). **1 coffee chat.**
Fri	✅	**Publish #15 PPE** to GitHub + Notion (project **5/10** ✅). **LinkedIn post #5.** Networking event or 2nd chat.
Sat	🎓 Class 9–6 · night OFF 🔒	No work after class. Rest — you earned the halfway mark.
Sun	✅	**#3 Amazon return-fraud [FLAGSHIP] kickoff** — scope the problem + find public e-commerce/returns data. Overflow + assignment buffer + **weekly review**.

📚 Where to study / resources this week

- **Python (file I/O + pandas):** Angela Yu "100 Days of Code" Days 11–17, then **Kaggle Pandas 1–3**. Understand-every-line — this is your interview insurance. See Skills.
- **Projects:** Projects — #15 PPE case-study format; #3 Amazon fraud reuses your Uber fraud-triage instincts on public returns data.
- **Book:** *The Pyramid Principle* Ch 4–6 — Reading.
- **Networking:** templates + event ideas in Networking.

✅ Done by Sunday

- ☐ Python Days 11–17 complete (file I/O + pandas), every line understood
- ☐ Kaggle Pandas lessons 1–3 done
- ☐ #15 🏥 PPE finished, case study written, **published (5/10** ✅ **— halfway!)**
- ☐ #3 Amazon return-fraud scoped: problem defined + public data located
- ☐ 2 coffee chats + 1 event + LinkedIn post #5
- ☐ *Pyramid Principle* Ch 4–6 read
- ☐ **Weekly review:** PPE live (5/10 ✅, halfway)? Amazon scoped?

← Week 9 · Index · Week 11 →

Week 11 · Sep 21–27 · BUILD — "Build flagship #2"

← Index

🎯 **This week's mission:** Get **#3 Amazon return-fraud** working — pandas deep + SQL/Python triage logic that produces real first findings. This is your fraud-triage DNA, proven in code.

Day	Status	What to do
Mon	🎓 Class 3–9pm	*Light only.* 30-min read: *Pyramid Principle* Ch 7. OR send 1 networking DM before class.
Tue	✅ (cap 3–4 hrs)	**Python pandas deep** — `groupby`, filtering, clean (every line, interview insurance). Then load the **#3 Amazon** returns data and start shaping the triage logic.
Wed	🎓 Class 6–9pm	2–3 hr block before class: **#3 Amazon** — write the SQL that segments returns; translate one slice into pandas.
Thu	✅ (cap 3–4 hrs)	**#3 Amazon** — build the Python triage/prioritization logic; pull **first findings** (a number you can point to). **1 coffee chat.**
Fri	✅	Skills: tidy the pandas cleaning steps so they're re-runnable. **Networking event or 2nd chat + 1 LinkedIn post.**
Sat	🎓 Class 9–6 · night OFF 🔒	No work after class. Rest.
Sun	✅	Tue/Thu overflow + **hackathon prep if registered** (Edge) + assignment buffer + **weekly review**.

📚 Where to study / resources this week

- **Python (pandas deep):** groupby, filtering, cleaning — Kaggle Pandas (lessons 4+) and the Angela Yu pandas sections. *Understand every line* — this is your interview insurance. See Skills.
- **Project #3 Amazon return-fraud [FLAGSHIP]:** recreate your Uber fraud-triage instincts on public e-commerce/returns data — SQL to segment, Python to prioritize. Case-study format and data pointers in Projects.
- **Book:** *The Pyramid Principle* Ch 7+ — Reading.
- **Networking:** chat targets + event ideas in Networking.

✅ Done by Sunday

- ☐ Pandas deep done (groupby, filtering, cleaning), every line understood
- ☐ #3 Amazon: SQL segmentation queries written
- ☐ #3 Amazon: Python triage/prioritization logic **running** with first findings (a real number)
- ☐ Cleaning steps re-runnable (not a one-off scratch script)
- ☐ 2 coffee chats + 1 event + 1 LinkedIn post
- ☐ *Pyramid Principle* Ch 7+ read
- ☐ Hackathon prep done (if registered)
- ☐ **Weekly review:** Is the Amazon triage logic working?

← Week 10 · Index · Week 12 →

Week 12 · Sep 28–Oct 4 · BUILD — "Flagship #2 launches, fraud spin-off"

← Index

🎯 **This week's mission:** Ship **Amazon return-fraud [Flagship #2]** — publish the case study (project 6 of 10, past halfway) — and kick off the fraud-pattern spin-off that reuses the same work.

Day by day

Day	Status	What to do
Mon	🎓 Class 3–9pm	*Light only.* Finish the last chapters of **The Pyramid Principle** (30-min read) OR send 1 networking DM before class.
Tue	✅ Free (cap 3–4 hrs)	**Python** — finish pandas (groupby / filtering / clean wrap-up). Apply it to **#3 Amazon fraud**: firm up the triage logic and pull your key finding *(with a number)*.
Wed	🎓 Class 6–9pm	2–3 hr block before class: optional light intro to a simple model on the fraud data (skip if tight). Write up the finding + the **recommendation** (your differentiator layer).
Thu	✅ Free (cap 3–4 hrs)	**#3 Amazon fraud** — write the full case study: Problem → Approach → Finding → What I built → **Recommendation** → What I'd do next. **+ 1 coffee chat.**
Fri	✅ Free	Publish **#3 Amazon** to GitHub + Notion (6/10 ✅). Post **LinkedIn #6** (flagship #2 launch + repo link). **+ networking event / 2nd chat.**
Sat	🎓 Class 9–6 · **night OFF** 🔒	No work after class.
Sun	✅ Free	Kick off **#13 Fraud-pattern detection [L]** — scope it reusing the Amazon triage work. Clear Tue/Thu overflow + assignment buffer. **Weekly review (15 min).**

📚 Where to study / resources this week

- **Python (finish pandas):** Kaggle *Pandas* course + Angela Yu "100 Days" — wrap groupby, filtering, cleaning. Detail → ../01-skills.md
- **Project #3 Amazon return-fraud + #13 spin-off:** case-study format & data sources → ../02-projects.md
- **Book:** finish *The Pyramid Principle* → ../04-reading-list.md
- **Networking (2 chats, 1 event, post #6):** ../03-networking.md

✅ Done by Sunday

- □ Python: pandas finished (understood every line — interview insurance)
- □ #3 Amazon fraud case study written (Problem → … → Recommendation)
- □ #3 Amazon **published & LIVE** on GitHub + Notion — **project 6 of 10** ✅
- □ LinkedIn post #6 up (flagship #2 launch + repo link)
- □ 2 coffee/alumni chats + 1 event done

- □ #13 Fraud-pattern detection scoped (reusing Amazon work)
- □ *The Pyramid Principle* finished
- □ **Review question:** Is **flagship #2 LIVE**?

← Week 11 · Index · Week 13 →

Week 13 · Oct 5–11 · BUILD — Vibe-coding + capstone start

← Index

🎯 **This week's mission:** Ship project #13 (7 of 10 ✅), taste vibe-coding by building one small app with AI, and scope the Rideshare capstone so next week is pure building.

Day	Status	What to do
Mon	🎓 Class 3–9pm	*Light only.* Read *Financial Intelligence* Ch 1 (30 min) **or** send 1 networking DM to line up this week's 2 chats.
Tue	✅ Free (cap 3–4 hrs)	**Vibe-coding:** build a small working app with your AI coding assistant — ship-fast, just understand the shape. Then push **#13 Fraud-pattern** toward done: finalize the SQL + Python rules, draft the case study (Problem → … → Recommendation).
Wed	🎓 Class 6–9pm	2–3 hr block before class: polish the vibe-coded app into a reusable light-project artifact. *Financial Intelligence* Ch 2.
Thu	✅ Free (cap 3–4 hrs)	**Finish #13 Fraud-pattern + publish** to GitHub + Notion (project **7 of 10** ✅). **Coffee chat #1** (aim: a Program/Project Manager). Start scoping the capstone.
Fri	✅ Free	Skills → **#5 Rideshare cancellation [FLAGSHIP/capstone] kickoff:** find public data, write the problem statement + 5 business questions. **1 networking event or 2nd alumni chat. LinkedIn post** — announce the fraud-pattern launch (7/10).
Sat	🎓 Class 9–6 · night OFF 🔒	No work after class. Only exception: a **hackathon** session *if one is actually scheduled* this weekend (edge — optional).
Sun	✅ Free	Tue/Thu overflow + assignment buffer. Finish capstone scoping (problem + 5 questions + data loaded). *Financial Intelligence* Ch 3. **Weekly review (15 min).**

📚 Where to study / resources this week

- **Vibe-coding** → build one small app with your AI coding assistant (ship-fast, understand the shape). Detail: ../01-skills.md.
- **Projects** → #13 case-study format + #5 Rideshare capstone (SQL + Python + Power BI): ../02-projects.md.
- **Book** → *Financial Intelligence* Ch 1–3: ../04-reading-list.md.
- **Networking** → 2 chats + 1 event templates: ../03-networking.md.

✅ Done by Sunday

- □ Vibe-coding: one small app built with AI (you get the shape)
- □ **#13 Fraud-pattern detection finished + published** (project 7 of 10 ✅)
- □ **#5 Rideshare capstone scoped** — problem statement + 5 business questions + public data loaded
- □ *Financial Intelligence* Ch 1–3 read

- □ 2 coffee/alumni chats done + 1 networking event
- □ 1 LinkedIn post (fraud-pattern launch)
- □ Weekly review — **Sun question: capstone scoped?**

You're two-thirds through the portfolio and standing at the capstone start line. Get it framed cleanly this week and the last three weeks of BUILD will fly. 🚀

← Week 12 · Index · Week 14 →

Week 14 · Oct 12–18 · BUILD — "Build the capstone"

← Index

🎯 **This week's mission:** Wire your capstone (Rideshare cancellation) into one clean SQL → Python → Power BI flow, and kick off OPEN slot A — your own idea.

Day	Status	What to do
Mon	🎓 Class 3–9pm	*Light only.* Read *Financial Intelligence* Ch 4 (~30 min) OR send 1 networking DM before class.
Tue	✅ Free (cap 3–4 hrs)	**Vibe-coding:** polish your app, connect the pieces. **#5 Rideshare [F]:** get the SQL layer clean (cancellation queries feeding downstream). Overflow → Sun.
Wed	🎓 Class 6–9pm	2–3 hr block before class: **#5 Rideshare** — Python layer (pandas: clean + shape the SQL output).
Thu	✅ Free (cap 3–4 hrs)	**#5 Rideshare:** pipe Python results into Power BI; sketch the dashboard. **+ 1 coffee chat.** Overflow → Sun.
Fri	✅ Free	**OPEN slot A kickoff** — scope your own idea (problem + 3–5 questions + data source). **Networking event / 2nd chat. LinkedIn post #7.**
Sat	🎓 Class 9–6 · night OFF 🔒	No work after class. Family call / gym.
Sun	✅ Free	Tue/Thu overflow + assignment buffer. Read *Financial Intelligence* Ch 5–6. **Weekly review (15 min).**

📚 Where to study / resources this week

- **Vibe-coding** — polish the app; focus on *connecting* SQL → Python → Power BI into one flow, not new features. Detail: ../01-skills.md
- **Capstone #5 (Rideshare cancellation)** — end-to-end pipeline is the goal, not perfection. Detail: ../02-projects.md
- **Book:** *Financial Intelligence* Ch 4–6. See ../04-reading-list.md
- **Networking** cadence + LinkedIn post template: ../03-networking.md

✅ Done by Sunday

- □ Rideshare capstone runs end-to-end: SQL → Python → Power BI, one connected flow
- □ OPEN slot A scoped (problem + questions + data source picked)
- □ LinkedIn post #7 published
- □ 2 coffee/alumni chats + 1 networking event
- □ *Financial Intelligence* Ch 4–6 read
- □ Weekly review: **Is the capstone pipeline working end-to-end?**

← Week 13 · Index · Week 15 →

Week 15 · Oct 19–25 · BUILD — "Capstone launches"

← Index

🎯 **This week's mission:** Land the flagship. Ship the Rideshare capstone with a killer recommendation, then close OPEN slot A — that's 9 of 10 projects live.

> This is a **consolidation week — no new skill.** You already have the tools. Everything this week is *applying* Excel/SQL/Python/Power BI to finish strong. Breathe: you're almost there.

Day-by-day

Day	Status	What to do
Mon	🎓 Class 3–9pm	*Light only.* Before class: read *Financial Intelligence* Ch 7 (30 min) **or** send 1 DM to lock in this week's coffee chat.
Tue	✅ (cap 3–4 hrs)	**#5 Rideshare [F]** final push. Tighten the SQL → Python → Power BI flow end-to-end; lock the **key finding + the number**. No new skill — polish what you built.
Wed	🎓 Class 6–9pm	2–3 hr block before class: **write the Rideshare case study** in the flagship format (Problem → Approach → Key finding → What I built → **Recommendation** → Next). Spend most of it on the Recommendation — that's your edge.
Thu	✅ (cap 3–4 hrs)	**Publish #5 Rideshare** to GitHub + Notion → **project 8 of 10** ✅**.** Then **coffee chat #1** (aim for a Program Manager).
Fri	✅	**OPEN slot A** — build your own-idea project (reuse this cycle's skills, ship-fast). Networking **event or 2nd chat**. **LinkedIn post:** share the capstone launch + GitHub link.
Sat	🎓 Class 9–6 · night OFF 🔒	No work after class. Protected.
Sun	✅	Finish + publish **OPEN slot A** → **9 of 10** ✅**.** Tue/Thu overflow + assignment buffer. **Weekly review (15 min).**

📚 Where to study / resources this week

- **Skill:** none new — reread the flagship case-study format so the Rideshare write-up matches your other 7.
- **Book:** *Financial Intelligence* Ch 7+ → reading list.
- **Projects:** capstone + OPEN slot A detail → projects. **Networking** cadence → networking.

✅ Done by Sunday

- ☐ #5 Rideshare capstone finished + full case study **published** (project 8 of 10 ✅)
- ☐ OPEN slot A finished + **published** (project 9 of 10 ✅)
- ☐ *Financial Intelligence* Ch 7+ read

- □ 2 coffee chats + 1 networking event
- □ 1 LinkedIn post (capstone launch + link)
- □ **Weekly review question: Is the capstone LIVE?**

← Week 14 · Index · Week 16 →

Week 16 · Oct 26–Nov 1 · BUILD · ⭐ BUILD ENDS — portfolio complete

← Index

🎯 **This week's mission:** Ship project #10, polish all 10 case studies to one clean format, and cross the finish line — this is the last week of BUILD.

Day	Status	What to do
Mon	🎓 Class 3–9pm	*Light only.* 30 min: read the final chapters of *Financial Intelligence* before class.
Tue	✅ Free (cap 3–4 hrs)	**OPEN slot B — finish it.** This is project 10 of 10. Build → write the case study → publish to GitHub + Notion.
Wed	🎓 Class 6–9pm	2–3 hr block before class: **start the polish pass.** Re-read your 3 flagships (Starbucks, Amazon, Rideshare) — make each follow the exact format.
Thu	✅ Free (cap 3–4 hrs)	Continue the polish pass on the 7 light projects + **coffee chat #1.** Overflow → Sun.
Fri	✅ Free	**Finish *Financial Intelligence*** (last skill task of BUILD). **Networking event or 2nd chat. LinkedIn post #8 — "My portfolio is complete: 10 projects."** Link it.
Sat	🎓 Class 9–6 · night OFF 🔒	No work after class. You earned it.
Sun	✅ Free	Overflow + assignment buffer + **weekly review =** ⭐ **END-OF-BUILD CHECK** (below). Final QA on all 10 case studies.

> **Edge (optional):** if a case competition is live this week, join it — great résumé line + team networking. Skip guilt-free if energy is tight.

📚 Where to study / resources this week

- **Book:** *Financial Intelligence* (Berman & Knight) — final chapters. Finish it this week. See Reading.
- **Case-study format** (apply to all 10): Problem → Approach → Key finding *(with a number)* → What I built → **Recommendation** → What I'd do next. Detail on Projects.
- **Portfolio polish:** one clean Notion page — About → 3 flagships with big impact numbers → 7 light projects in a grid → resume + LinkedIn links.
- No new skill this week — consolidate. Skills detail on Skills; networking cadence on Networking.

✅ Done by Sunday

- □ OPEN slot B built, written up, and published — **project 10 of 10 live**
- □ *Financial Intelligence* finished
- □ All 10 case studies in the identical Problem→Recommendation→Next format
- □ Every project ends in a clear recommendation (your differentiator — the strategy, not the query)

- □ 2 coffee chats + 1 event done
- □ LinkedIn post #8 published (portfolio complete) with link
- □ Weekly review done

⭐ END-OF-BUILD CHECK (Sunday — the big one)

- □ **10 projects live** on the portfolio?
- □ **Excel / SQL / Power BI / Python** credible — can you say "*I built this*" about each?
- □ **25+ networking chats** done across the phase?
- □ **Portfolio ready for Polish** — clean, public-able, links in place?

If all four are yes: BUILD is done. Take a breath — you built a proof-backed brand from scratch in 16 weeks. Next stop, POLISH.

← Week 15 · Index · Week 17 →

Week 17 · Nov 2–8 · POLISH — Portfolio goes fully LIVE

← Index

> 🎯 **This week's mission:** Build is done — now make it *visible*. Toggle the portfolio public, wire it into LinkedIn + your resume, and turn 10 projects + your Uber years into crisp STAR stories you can tell out loud.

Build ended last week. This is the first Polish week: no new skills, no new projects. Everything you do now points at one thing — a hiring manager can find your work in 10 seconds and you can walk them through it in 5 minutes.

Day-by-day

Day	Status	What to do
Mon	🎓 Class 3–9pm	*Light only.* Start ***Making Things Happen*** (Berkun) — 30-min read before class. Or send 1 networking DM.
Tue	✅ Free (cap 3–4 hrs)	**Portfolio final layout** in Notion: About → 3 flagships with big impact numbers → 7 light projects in a grid → resume + LinkedIn links. Then draft **STAR answers #1–2** (Pyramid-structured, from Uber).
Wed	🎓 Class 6–9pm	2–3 hr block before class: write **STAR answers #3–4** (from your projects). *Consulting case prep (~1 session) — only if you kept it in Week 6.*
Thu	✅ Free (cap 3–4 hrs)	**Go live:** toggle portfolio public → add it to **LinkedIn Featured** + **resume header**. Then **coffee chat #1** — ask this contact for a referral.
Fri	✅ Free	Write **STAR answer #5**. **Networking event / 2nd chat** — ask a 2nd contact for a referral. **LinkedIn post #9:** "My portfolio is live" + the link.
Sat	🎓 Class 9–6 · night OFF 🔒	No work after class.
Sun	✅ Free	**Mock interview #1** (behavioral + portfolio walkthrough) with a classmate or friend. Tue/Thu overflow + assignment buffer. **Weekly review (15 min).**

📚 Where to study / resources this week

- **Portfolio format & home layout** → Projects (the consistent Problem → Approach → Finding → What I built → **Recommendation** → Next case-study shape).
- **STAR + referral-ask templates** → Networking (Pyramid Principle structure carries straight into STAR answers).
- **This week's book** → *Making Things Happen* (Scott Berkun) — see Reading list.
- **Case prep (only if kept)** → Consulting.

✅ Done by Sunday

- □ Notion portfolio final layout complete (About + 3 flagships + 7 light + links)
- □ Portfolio toggled **PUBLIC**
- □ Portfolio link added to **LinkedIn Featured** + **resume header**
- □ **5 STAR answers** written, Pyramid-structured
- □ **Mock interview #1** done (behavioral + portfolio walkthrough)
- □ 2 coffee/alumni chats + 1 event + **2 referral asks**
- □ LinkedIn post #9 published
- □ *Making Things Happen* started
- □ **Sun review question:** Is the portfolio public + linked everywhere (LinkedIn, resume, signature)?

You spent 16 weeks earning the right to say "I built this." This week you point everyone to the proof. Ship it loud.

← Week 16 · Index · Week 18 →

Week 18 · Nov 9–15 · POLISH — Sharpen the story

← Index

🎯 **This week's mission:** Turn a finished portfolio into a *sellable* one — every resume bullet in PM/ops language, a crisp walkthrough script, and 5 more STAR answers you can say out loud.

> You are past the build. The work now is words: how you frame Uber, how you narrate your projects, how you land the recommendation. This is your home turf.

Day-by-day

Day	Status	What to do
Mon	🎓 Class 3–9pm	*Light only.* Before class: send **referral ask #1** (one warm contact — Template in Networking).
Tue	✅ Free (cap 3–4 hrs)	**Resume final rewrite** — rework *every* bullet into PM/ops verbs (owned, launched, drove, cut, standardized). Lead with the outcome + a number.
Wed	🎓 Class 6–9pm	2–3 hr block before class: **Portfolio walkthrough script** — 60-sec intro + one tight paragraph per flagship (Problem → what I built → *finding with a number* → recommendation).
Thu	✅ Free (cap 3–4 hrs)	Write **5 more STAR answers** (Pyramid-structured: answer first, then S-T-A-R) from Uber + projects. **Coffee chat #1.**
Fri	✅ Free	**Record yourself** doing the walkthrough + 2 STAR answers; watch it back once, note 3 fixes. Networking **event / 2nd chat** + **referral ask #2** + **1 LinkedIn post** (share a portfolio highlight).
Sat	🎓 Class 9–6 · night OFF 🔒	Class only. No work tonight. Family / rest.
Sun	✅ Free	**Mock #2** (behavioral + portfolio walkthrough — book a peer/mentor). Tue/Thu overflow + assignment buffer + **weekly review**.

📚 Where to study / resources this week

- **Story craft:** structure every STAR answer top-down (Pyramid Principle, finished wk 12 — answer first, support after). Detail in Reading.
- **Walkthrough script:** pull each flagship's Problem→…→Recommendation from your case studies in Projects.
- **Referrals + asks:** reuse the referral-ask and informational-interview templates in Networking.
- **Browsable book:** continue *Making Things Happen* (started wk 17) — light, PM-craft reading.

✅ Done by Sunday

- □ Resume **final** — every bullet in PM/ops language, outcome + number first
- □ Portfolio walkthrough script written (each flagship → number + recommendation)

- □ 5 more STAR answers drafted (Pyramid-structured — total 10)
- □ Recorded yourself once + watched it back (3 fixes noted)
- □ Mock #2 complete
- □ 2 coffee chats + 1 event
- □ 2 referral asks sent
- □ 1 LinkedIn post shared
- □ **Weekly review (15 min):** *Is the resume final?*

← Week 17 · Index · Week 19 →

Week 19 · Nov 16–22 · POLISH — Company-target the pipeline

← Index

🎯 **This week's mission:** Turn "I have a portfolio" into "I know exactly who I'm targeting and I have the right résumé for each." Build the dream-company tracker, tailor 3 résumé variants, and run a company-specific mock.

Day	Status	What to do
Mon	🎓 Class 3–9pm	*Light only.* Before class: 30-min browsable-menu read (*Making Things Happen*) **or** send 1 DM to a dream-company contact. Start jotting your dream list.
Tue	✅ Free (cap 3–4 hrs)	**Build the target-company tracker** — dream list (Starbucks, IKEA, Amazon, Uber, Spotify + your picks) with **2 named contacts each**. Find them via LinkedIn/alumni.
Wed	🎓 Class 6–9pm	2–3 hr block before class: **Draft résumé variant #1 — Program/Project Manager.** Every bullet in PM language (own the program, cross-functional, risk).
Thu	✅ Free (cap 3–4 hrs)	**Draft variants #2 (Ops/Supply Chain) + #3 (Risk/Governance).** + **1 coffee chat** — and **convert a referral ask** while you're there. Overflow → Sun.
Fri	✅ Free	**Mock #3 (company-specific)** using your tracker + variants. + **networking event / 2nd chat** (2nd referral ask). + **1 LinkedIn post.**
Sat	🎓 Class 9–6 · night OFF 🔒	Class only. No work after. Rest — you've earned it.
Sun	✅ Free	Tue/Thu overflow + finalize tracker & all 3 variants + assignment buffer + **weekly review (15 min).**

📚 Where to study / resources this week

- **Tracker + referral cadence + contact templates:** Networking — reuse Template 1/2, log dream list + 2 contacts each.
- **Résumé variants (PM / Ops / Risk):** anchor every bullet to your brand line and target roles. Lead with cross-functional, communication, **risk**, stakeholder mgmt — the 88/74/72/66% your own data says PMs are hired for.
- **Mock #3 prep:** Interview / stories if you kept case prep; otherwise use your Week 17–18 STAR set, tuned to one target company.
- **Book (browsable menu):** Reading list — keep dipping into *Making Things Happen*.

✅ Done by Sunday

- ☐ Target-company tracker built — dream list + **2 named contacts each**
- ☐ 3 résumé variants tailored: **PM / Ops / Risk**
- ☐ Mock #3 (company-specific) done + notes captured
- ☐ 2 coffee/alumni chats + 1 networking event

- □ Referral asks converted (follow-ups sent)
- □ 1 LinkedIn post
- □ Weekly review (15 min) — **"Tracker built, variants ready?"**

← Week 18 · Index · Week 20 →

Week 20 · Nov 23–29 · POLISH — "Ready to launch"

← Index

🎯 **This week's mission:** Get everything launch-ready — QA the portfolio and resume to zero defects, dry-run 5 applications (don't submit), run your 4th mock, and rest before the December sprint.

Day-by-day

Day	Status	What to do
Mon	🎓 Class 3–9pm	*Light only.* Reread one STAR answer out loud OR send 1 networking DM before class. That's it — save your energy.
Tue	✅ (cap 3–4 hrs)	**Final portfolio QA.** Walk all 10 case studies: same Problem→…→Recommendation format, every impact number stated, every link works, no typos. Fix as you go.
Wed	🎓 Class 6–9pm	*2–3 hr block before class.* **Final resume QA** — proofread all 3 variants (PM / Ops / Risk); confirm every bullet reads in PM/ops language and matches the portfolio.
Thu	✅ (cap 3–4 hrs)	**Dry-run applications 1–3** (fill them out completely, do NOT submit) + **1 coffee chat**. Thanksgiving week — if the chat can't land today, move it earlier or to Fri.
Fri	✅	**Dry-run applications 4–5** + **networking event / 2nd chat** + **1 LinkedIn post** (share a portfolio piece or a "ready to interview" reflection).
Sat	🎓 Class 9–6 · night OFF 🔒	No work after class.
Sun	✅	**Mock interview #4** (behavioral + full portfolio walkthrough — record it or run with a peer) → finish any overflow → **weekly review =** ⭐ **POLISH CHECK** (below).

📚 Where to study / resources this week

No new skill — this is a polish-and-QA week. Focus your reps here:
- **Portfolio QA** → walk the 10 case studies on your Notion page; hold each to the consistent format. Detail: ../02-projects.md
- **Networking & referrals** → 2 chats + 1 event; keep referral asks converting. Cadence + target tracker: ../03-networking.md
- **Mock #4 + stories** → run the behavioral + walkthrough end-to-end; tighten any STAR answer that felt shaky.
- **Optional reading** → 30 min from the browsable menu (e.g. *Making Things Happen*): ../04-reading-list.md

✅ Done by Sunday

- □ Portfolio QA'd — 10 case studies consistent, impact numbers + links verified
- □ Resume QA'd — 3 variants (PM / Ops / Risk) final and proofed
- □ 5 applications dry-run (filled, **not** submitted)

- ☐ Mock interview #4 complete (behavioral + portfolio walkthrough)
- ☐ 2 coffee chats + 1 event done; referral asks still moving
- ☐ 1 LinkedIn post published
- ☐ Rested — actually took the holiday downtime before December

⭐ POLISH CHECK (end-of-phase gate)

- ☐ Portfolio LIVE and linked everywhere (LinkedIn Featured + resume header)
- ☐ Stories sharp — STAR answers Pyramid-structured, told without notes
- ☐ 4 mocks done
- ☐ Target-company tracker ready (dream list + 2 contacts each)
- ☐ Referrals in motion

Sun review question: *Portfolio live, stories sharp, 4 mocks done, tracker ready, referrals in motion — am I ready to hit MARKET on Dec 1?*

You built the whole engine over 16 weeks and polished it over 4. This is the last calm week — QA hard, rest well, and walk into December ready to launch. 🚀

← Week 19 · Index · Week 21 →

Week 21 · Nov 30 – Dec 6 · MARKET — "Hit the market"

← Index

> 🎯 **This week's mission:** Go live. Send **5 tailored applications** to dream + target companies, and turn every chat into a "flag me openings" ask. Build is done, portfolio is live — now the portfolio does the talking.

The skills grind is over. From here, your free blocks are **apply + prep** blocks. Quality over volume: 5 sharp, tailored apps beat 20 sprayed ones.

Day-by-day

Day	Status	What to do
Mon	🎓 Class 3–9pm (light only)	Before class: send **1 networking DM** asking a contact to flag openings. Skim find-jobs fresh listings 15 min; bookmark 5–8 roles.
Tue	✅ Free (cap 3–4 hrs)	Run find-jobs, shortlist the 5 best-fit roles (dream first). Tailor + **submit apps #1–2** (resume variant + portfolio link).
Wed	🎓 Class 6–9pm	2–3 hr block before class: tailor + **submit app #3**. Draft 3 tight talking points for your top-choice role.
Thu	✅ Free (cap 3–4 hrs)	**Submit apps #4–5. Coffee chat #1** — ask them directly to flag/refer openings at their company.
Fri	✅ Free	**Coffee chat #2 / networking event. LinkedIn post** ("Portfolio's live — here's what I built, and I'm now looking for PM/ops roles").
Sat	🎓 Class 9–6 · night OFF 🔒	No work after class. Rest — December is a sprint.
Sun	✅ Free	Overflow: finish any of the 5 apps not yet in. **Prep for early responses** (portfolio walkthrough, top STAR answers). Assignment buffer. **Weekly review (15 min).**

📚 Where to study / resources this week

- **Fresh listings + tailoring:** the find-jobs pipeline — pull today's Seattle + national PM/ops openings, filter to dream + target companies.
- **Referral asks & templates:** Networking — reuse the referral-ask cadence and message templates.
- **What to link in each app:** your live portfolio + 3 flagships — see Projects.
- **Resume variants (PM / Ops / Risk):** finalized in Week 19 — pick the right one per role.

✅ Done by Sunday

- ☐ **5 quality, tailored applications submitted** (dream + target companies)
- ☐ 2 coffee chats done — both asked to flag/refer openings
- ☐ 1 networking event attended

- □ 1 LinkedIn post live ("portfolio live + open to roles")
- □ Talking points + portfolio walkthrough ready for early responses
- □ **Weekly review:** *Are 5 quality apps in?* Which company excites you most — and who can refer you there?

← Week 20 · Index · Week 22 →

Week 22 · Dec 7–13 · MARKET — "Ramp applications"

← Index

🎯 **This week's mission:** Double your pipeline — 5 more tailored apps (10 total), follow up on Week 21, and turn warm contacts into direct referral asks at your dream companies.

> You're past the build. The portfolio does the talking now — your job is volume with aim. Every app is tailored, every dream company gets a human ask.

Day-by-day

Day	Status	What to do
Mon	🎓 Class 3–9pm	*Light only.* Before class: send **1 referral DM** to a target-company contact (warm ask, name the role).
Tue	✅ (cap 3–4 hrs)	**Apps #6–7** — tailor résumé variant + portfolio link to each JD. Log in tracker.
Wed	🎓 Class 6–9pm	2–3 hr block before class: **interview prep** — rehearse portfolio walkthrough + 2 STAR stories for the company most likely to respond.
Thu	✅ (cap 3–4 hrs)	**Apps #8–9** + **1 coffee chat** (ask them to flag/refer openings). Overflow → Sun.
Fri	✅	**App #10** + **networking event / 2nd chat** + **LinkedIn post** (share a flagship result). Send **2 direct referral asks** at target companies.
Sat	🎓 Class 9–6 · night OFF 🔒	No work after class. Rest — you're sprinting.
Sun	✅	Tue/Thu overflow + **follow up on all Week-21 apps** (polite nudge / referral ping) + assignment buffer + **weekly review (15 min)**.

📚 Where to study / resources this week

- **Fresh listings:** run the `/find-jobs` pipeline for new dream + target-company roles — see ../../CLAUDE.md.
- **Referral asks & templates:** ../03-networking.md — reuse the referral-ask cadence; personalize each one.
- **Résumé variants (PM / Ops / Risk):** built in Week 19 — match the variant to each JD.
- **Interview prep:** your STAR answers + portfolio walkthrough script (Weeks 17–18); ../02-projects.md for flagship talking points.

✅ Done by Sunday

- ☐ 5 tailored applications submitted (10 total for MARKET so far)
- ☐ All Week-21 apps followed up on
- ☐ 2 coffee chats done
- ☐ 2+ direct referral asks sent at target companies

- □ 1 LinkedIn post live
- □ Interview prep rehearsed for at least 1 company
- □ Weekly review: **any movement?** (responses, referrals in flight, loops opening — note what to push next week)

← Week 21 · Index · Week 23 →

Week 23 · Dec 14–20 · MARKET — "Interview mode"

← Index

🎯 **This week's mission:** Keep the pipeline full (5 more apps → 15+ total) while your real focus shifts to *winning live loops* — company-specific prep and crisp portfolio walkthroughs.

> The portfolio does the talking; you do the closing. This week, apps are maintenance — interviews are the main event. Prep each loop like it's the one.

Day-by-day

Day	Status	What to do
Mon	🎓 Class 3–9pm	*Light only.* Before class: **check in with 1 contact** at a company where you have a live loop or pending app (warm nudge, thank them).
Tue	✅ (cap 3–4 hrs)	**Company-specific interview prep** for your most active loop — research the org, tailor 3 STAR stories to their JD, rehearse the portfolio walkthrough.
Wed	🎓 Class 6–9pm	2–3 hr block before class: **Apps #11–12** — tailor the right résumé variant (PM / Ops / Risk) + portfolio link to each JD. Log in tracker.
Thu	✅ (cap 3–4 hrs)	**Apps #13–14** + **1 coffee chat** (ask them to flag openings / intro you). More loop prep if a loop is scheduled. Overflow → Sun.
Fri	✅	**App #15** + **networking event / 2nd chat** + **LinkedIn post** (a flagship result or an interview-season insight). **Check in with 2 contacts** on pending apps.
Sat	🎓 Class 9–6 · night OFF 🔒	No work after class. Rest before any weekday loops.
Sun	✅	Tue/Thu overflow + **follow up on all live loops & prior apps** + assignment buffer + **weekly review (15 min)**.

📚 Where to study / resources this week

- **Interview prep** — your 5+ STAR answers + portfolio walkthrough script (built Weeks 17–18); flagship talking points on ../02-projects.md.
- **Fresh listings** — run the `/find-jobs` pipeline for new dream + target-company roles: ../../CLAUDE.md.
- **Résumé variants (PM / Ops / Risk)** — match the variant to each JD; built Week 19.
- **Referral & check-in templates** — ../03-networking.md; personalize every message.

✅ Done by Sunday

- ☐ 5 tailored applications submitted (**15+ total** for MARKET)
- ☐ Company-specific prep done for every live interview loop
- ☐ At least 1 portfolio walkthrough rehearsed out loud

- □ 2 coffee chats done + 1 networking event
- □ Checked in with contacts on pending apps / loops
- □ 1 LinkedIn post live
- □ Weekly review — **Sun question: interview loops live?** (note which stage each is at + next action)

You built the proof, you did the outreach — now the interviews are yours to win. Prep deep, walk them through your work, and let the recommendations (your edge) do the closing. 🎯

← Week 22 · Index · Week 24 →

Week 24 · Dec 21–27 · MARKET — "Reflect + sustain"

← Index

🎯 **This week's mission:** Land 5 more quality applications (**20+ total**), keep your interview loops warm, and close the year by naming what's working — then set the January engine so momentum never stalls. This is a holiday week: work the plan in focused bursts, then let yourself rest. You built the whole thing. Now it does the talking.

⭐ YEAR-END CHECK (do this Sunday)

- ☐ **20+ applications** submitted (dream + target companies)
- ☐ **Interview loops in motion** — every active loop prepped per company
- ☐ **Portfolio is doing the talking** — links live in resume header + LinkedIn Featured, walkthrough script ready

Day-by-day

Day	Status	What to do
Mon	🎓 Class 3–9pm	*Light only.* 30 min: review your interview-loop status board + send 1 networking check-in DM before class.
Tue	✅ (cap 3–4 hrs)	Draft + submit **2–3 tailored applications** (dream + target). Pull fresh listings via the find-jobs pipeline. Prep any active loop between drafts.
Wed	🎓 Class 6–9pm	2–3 hr block before class: submit the **remaining apps to hit 5 this week** (→ 20+ total). Company-specific interview prep for your live loops.
Thu	✅ (cap 3–4 hrs)	Active-loop work: rehearse portfolio walkthrough out loud, per company. **+ 1 coffee chat** — check in with a key contact, ask them to flag openings.
Fri	✅	**2nd chat / event** check-in + **LinkedIn post #9** (year-end reflection: what you built + gratitude). Follow up on week-21→23 apps.
Sat	🎓 Class 9–6 · **night OFF** 🔒	No work after class. Rest — it's the holidays. You earned it.
Sun	✅	Overflow + **weekly review**. Reflect: what's working, what to adjust for January. Run the ⭐ Year-End Check above. Lock the January cadence.

📚 Where to study / resources this week

No new skills this week — you're in market mode. Point your energy at:
- **Applications:** the find-jobs pipeline for fresh, scored listings; tailor each to the JD.
- **Interviews:** your 5 STAR answers + portfolio walkthrough script from Polish weeks (see Networking for referral + follow-up templates).
- **Reflection:** re-read your brand line and thesis in the career map spec before you write the year-end note.

✅ Done by Sunday

- ☐ **5 more tailored applications** submitted → **20+ total** for the season
- ☐ Followed up on all earlier (wk 21–23) applications
- ☐ Every active interview loop prepped per company
- ☐ **LinkedIn post #9** (year-end reflection) published
- ☐ Year-end reflection written: *what's working, what to adjust for January*
- ☐ **January cadence set: 2 apps/day + 2 chats/week + 1 book/month** — until landed
- ☐ **Sun review:** ⭐ 20+ apps in, interview loops in motion, portfolio doing the talking?

This is the last scheduled week — but not the finish line. From here the cadence carries you: 2 applications a day, 2 chats a week, 1 book a month, until the offer lands. You've done the hard part. Keep showing up. 🎉

← Week 23 · Index